

Something to Count

Vera Shandles

The night of 11 December 2014

It had rained for eighteen days, until the river stood higher than the doorsteps of the houses beside it.

She drove along the foot of the bank with the wipers on full, past forty houses that had their shutters closed and their people asleep inside. On the other side of the road was the bank, a wall of clay as high as a house, and behind it the river. At the end of the row the care home had one light on, over its back door.

She stopped where the road ended and got out in the rain.

Water was coming through the bank. It ran down the clay in a sheet as wide as a door and crossed the road in her headlights. She put her hand flat on the bank beside the water and felt the clay move under her palm.

She had repaired that bank every spring for six years, so she knew what it could take. Ten more minutes, she thought. Then it would break.

She drove up onto the bank, to the floodgate. From up there the river was on one side of her and the fields were on the other, far below, dark and empty. The gate was there to let the river out onto those fields when it ran too high. It was raised by hand, from a platform of boards beside it. When she climbed onto the platform and pointed her torch at the water, it was going past just under the boards, close enough to touch.

She took the handle out of its box.

She held it for three breaths. Then she climbed back down to the van and turned it around on top of the bank, until its headlights pointed out over the fields, along the one track that crossed them.

She looked down that track while the wipers crossed the windscreen twice.

Then she took out her phone and rang a number that was already in it. She held the phone to her ear while the rain ran off her hood.

It rang once.

Tuesday 24 November 2026, 2:51 a.m.

Maylis Lesca was awake in her own bed and couldn't move.

She tried her right hand. Nothing. She tried her left, then both feet, then her jaw. Only her eyes still worked. She could see the ceiling, the paper lampshade, the top of the wardrobe and the red numbers of the clock radio. Rain was falling on the roof.

Something was sitting on the wardrobe.

It was about the size of a sheep and darker than the ceiling behind it. As she watched, it came down. It hit the floor like a full sack dropped off a trailer. When it crossed the room she heard dry leaves dragging over the boards. It jumped onto the bed, sat down on her chest and turned its back to her.

It was covered in overlapping brown leaves, and where the leaves parted there was grey steel underneath, with a row of rivets. It was heavy. She dug graves and lifted sacks of cement for a living, but she had never had to lift a sack off her own chest. It smelled of cold steel and old tobacco, in a house where nobody had ever smoked. She knew that smell.

She pushed up against the thing with all the breath she had, which wasn't much. She had cracked a rib on Monday, and that was why she was sleeping on her back in the first place. The thing pressed down just as hard. Beside her Coralie slept on, turned to the wall.

At 2:54 the little finger of her right hand moved against the blanket. The rest of the hand followed. The thing got down off her and left the way it had come, and by the time Coralie turned over there was nothing on top of the wardrobe.

Coralie found Maylis's wrist, put two fingers on the inside of it and watched the clock.

'Your pulse is 112,' she said. 'What's wrong?'

'It's the rib.'

'A rib doesn't give you 112. Have you been out of bed?'

'I've been lying here,' Maylis said.

‘Then you’re bad at it. I’ve got people of ninety who can lie on their backs all night without waking anybody.’

‘They’ve had the practice. This is my first night.’

Coralie shut her eyes again, but she kept her fingers where they were. ‘Do you need the toilet? At work that’s what it is, nine times out of ten.’

‘And the tenth?’

‘The tenth, we ring the priest.’

‘Don’t,’ Maylis said. ‘He’d only ring me to dig the hole.’

Coralie laughed into the pillow. ‘It’s slowing down,’ she said. ‘You’ll live. I can get you water, a pill or my pillow. What do you want, Maylis?’

‘Nothing. Go back to sleep.’

What she wanted was for Coralie to stay awake and keep her fingers on that wrist. But Coralie had to be up at 6, so Maylis didn’t ask.

She stayed awake and thought about the smell instead. It was the smell of the old tobacco-drying barn at the end of the village, where she had once sat for an afternoon and been paid for it.

Twelve years earlier, in June 2014, the village council had rented the barn to a team from a university. Inside it the team had built a steel room the size of a garden shed. The room had one chair in it and a panel with two lamps. A lot of steel for one chair.

‘One of these two lamps will come on,’ the woman from the university had told her at the door. ‘You’ll see which one. What we want to know is whether there is another you, somewhere, who sees the other one.’

Maylis asked where somewhere was. The woman said that was the question.

One lamp came on. Maylis wrote down which one on a card, put the card in an envelope and closed it. They opened the door, paid her, gave her a sandwich and went back to their university. The envelope went home with her, into a drawer.

She slept a little towards morning. When she woke there was a picture in her head that hadn’t been there before: a stone, standing in front of the town hall where the mayor parked his car. Grey granite, as high as her shoulder. Somebody had put it up straight. A name was cut into it in capitals: MAYLIS LESCA. Above hers was another name, which she couldn’t read. Under hers was a date. That she could read: 12 DECEMBER. A year came after it, but that part of the picture wouldn’t stay in her head.

Maylis dug the graves in Peyrebarthe, so she knew what a name and a date on a stone meant. It was the 24th of November. She counted the days. Eighteen.

She treated the stone as one more job and told nobody.

Coralie had left before it was light. She worked at the care home down in the Port, at the end of the forty houses that stood on the low ground behind the river bank.

Coralie's tomato plant on the kitchen windowsill still had one green tomato on it. Maylis would have pulled it up in October. The shopping pad was on the kitchen table. It said *Tonight*, then *soup*, then *the rest of the duck*, with a box drawn beside each choice. Maylis held the pencil over the duck. Then she wrote *Either* across the bottom and went out to the van. She was going to the square first, to look at the place where the mayor parked.

* * *

It rained all day Tuesday, straight down. Maylis was the village's only outdoor worker, so she spent the day in the square, raking leaves off the drain covers under the plane trees. Two trailers of leaves a week came off that square. Eighteen days made five trailers.

She raked left-handed, because of the rib. On Monday the mayor, Guy Larrère, had rung and told her to raise the floodgate down in the river bank. The handle had stuck and thrown her against the rail.

His car was parked in front of the town hall, in the space where the stone stood in her picture. Wherever she started, she raked her way back to it. The roof came up to her shoulder. So had the stone. Larrère was at the wheel with the engine running. He spent his mornings there, until the town hall opened at 2. By her count that was a tank of diesel a week, to go nowhere.

The post van came around the church. The postman was new, so he went to Larrère's window. Larrère lowered it a few centimetres, which was as far as it went for anybody.

'I've got a registered letter for the mayor,' the postman said into the gap. 'Who is also the president of the landowners' association, it says here. The town hall's shut. Where can I find him?'

'The town hall opens at 2.'

The postman turned to Maylis. Her yellow raincoat had COMMUNE DE PEYREBARTHE across its back.

'Is the man who works for the village around?'

'That's me,' Maylis said.

He looked at the rake. He looked at Larrère, who was looking at the church. Then he held out the receipt card and a pen.

She signed in the box, *M. Lesca*, with her father's tall L. Rain fell on the card and the ink of the L ran. The L cut in the stone wouldn't run.

'If you see the mayor,' the postman said through the gap, 'can you tell him it's come?'

'I'll tell him,' said Larrère.

The postman gave Maylis the envelope and drove away.

'You didn't have to sign so quickly,' Larrère said. 'Put it in my tray. I'll be brief. The handle.'

He closed his right hand around nothing and turned it behind the glass. 'Your father turned it with one hand. Like that.'

'It stuck on Monday,' she said. 'At nineteen turns.'

'So there's the question of the handle,' he said. 'It isn't settled, and you're not to worry about it.'

The window went up.

She had written to him three times about that handle. She went back to the leaves.

Jeannot Castagnet had watched from his white van, outside the café. Now he drove over and rolled his window all the way down.

'I watched him not sign it,' he said. 'I've paid for forty-one registered letters, just to get that man's name on a card, and it's little Lesca who signs for them.' He nodded towards the flood fields, where he shot ducks from his hut. It was a cellar dug into the field, under a trapdoor in the grass. 'One. The water down there is mine. A duck comes down onto standing water. On Sunday night I had a hand's width of water on those fields.' He laid his hand flat on the van door. 'That deep. Two. That gate lets water through both ways. On Monday the river was lower than my fields. You put the gate up, and my water ran out through it, down into the river. Last night I sat over mud.'

'I was told to raise it.'

'Three,' Jeannot said. He was looking at Larrère's car. 'He had that gate raised to let my water out. That's his answer to letter forty.'

'Put it in forty-two.'

He laughed. She started to laugh too, until the rib stopped her. He saw it happen.

'What have you done to yourself?'

‘A rib. The handle stuck.’

‘Then that goes in forty-two as well,’ he said. He wasn’t laughing any more.

He drove off. Maylis stood the rake upright beside the mayor’s car. Larrère looked at the church. She opened her pocket knife and cut eighteen marks down the rake, starting level with her shoulder.

* * *

Maylis came home at 7 that evening and found Coralie standing in the kitchen with the shopping pad in her hand.

‘I don’t cook Either,’ Coralie said. ‘There’s no recipe for it. Soup or duck.’

‘Whichever’s less trouble.’

‘That’s Either again, with more words.’

She dropped the pad on the table and pulled the dish towel off the oven door. Maylis was still standing there in her raincoat with her hair wet. Coralie rubbed it dry with the towel, hard.

‘The hill was clear of leaves when I drove down this morning, every bend of it. You do my road before the square, every autumn, and you’ve never once said so. Sixteen years, and you’ve told me once what you wanted. It was me. Eggs, then. Eggs are what Either gets in this house.’

Sixteen years earlier, in August 2010, Coralie had found her behind the tent on the last night of the village festival. Maylis was stacking chairs. Coralie took the top one out of her hands.

‘You’ve carried my shopping up from the Port twice now, and never said why. What do you want, Maylis?’

‘You,’ Maylis said.

Coralie put the chair back on the stack herself.

Now Coralie broke eggs into the pan. Maylis sat down a little at a time, the way the rib wanted it done, and told her about the registered letter, the postman and the man in the car who was looking at the church. She left out the stone.

‘He said he’d tell him?’ Coralie said.

‘He said, “I’ll tell him.” That’s forty-one Jeannot’s paid for. He’s spent more on stamps than the association has spent on its gate.’

Coralie laughed, with her head back.

Then she put the fork down, opened the oven door a few centimetres and bent down to speak through the gap.

‘I’ll be brief,’ she said, low, from the back of the throat. ‘The eggs. There’s the question of the eggs. It isn’t settled, and you’re not to worry about it.’ She looked at the oven shelf. ‘In my tray,’ she said, and shut the oven door.

Maylis laughed. The laugh got as far as the rib and the rib hurt. She pressed her forearm against her side, shut her eyes and went on laughing as much as she could.

‘Don’t,’ Coralie said. ‘No. Wait.’

She took the pan off the heat and went to get the first-aid box she had brought home from work. Maylis stayed in her chair while Coralie wrapped the wide bandage around her three times, over the T-shirt, and pulled it tight.

‘Now you can.’

‘It’s gone.’

‘Then I’ll do the handle,’ Coralie said. She faced the oven door, closed her hand around nothing and turned it. The laugh came back.

They ate the eggs out of the pan. Afterwards Coralie ticked both boxes herself, wrote *eggs* under them, drew a third box and ticked that one too.

At 10 Coralie pulled the blanket off the bed and shook it out. A few crumbs of brown leaf fell on the floor, as they had most nights for twelve years.

‘Those plane trees,’ she said. ‘You bring the square home in your hair.’

She got into bed on the side by the wall and was asleep before the light was off. Maylis turned it off at 10:10. Then she was lying on her back, looking at the top of the wardrobe.

At 2:51, the same minute as the night before, the thing came down off it again and sat on her chest.

This time somebody was under it with her. Not Coralie. Coralie was asleep by the wall.

On Wednesday it was still raining. Maylis woke up with another picture in her head.

In this one she was standing at the town hall door with the mayor's sash across her chest, blue, white and red. The square in front of her was full of people, all waiting for her to begin. In eighteen years the only thing that square had ever waited for her to do was move the tractor. The stone was still in her head too. Seventeen days.

Her father had always had the Christmas lights up in the plane trees by Saint Catherine's Day. That was today. With the rib she needed help to hang them, which gave her a reason to stop at the Labats' door on the way. Something had sat on Kévin Labat's chest as well. He had told the whole village about it. She wanted to know how he had got out from under it. She told his mother about the lights. By the time she had the shed unlocked, Kévin was standing at its door.

'My mum says you've cracked a rib, and you've got nine strings of lights to hang. Does it hurt? Can I go up in the bucket?'

'The village won't pay you,' Maylis said.

'It never has. Is that a yes?'

His van was parked by the first plane tree. He opened the back doors to get his gloves, and she saw two blue cool boxes tied along one side. Boxes like that were for glass eels, the baby eels that came up the river on the winter tides. A kilo of them sold for more than she earned in a week. A man could go to prison for catching them at a floodgate. Maylis kept the key to the floodgate, and to the padlock on its platform, so she turned her back on the open doors.

'You could look,' he said. 'All these winters, and you never have. Don't you want to know?'

'I've got lights to hang.'

He left his phone on the dashboard of the village tractor, out of the rain. Then he climbed into the bucket on the front of the tractor with a string of lights over his shoulder, and she sent him up into the tree, working the levers left-handed. He pulled the string tighter than she would have.

At 9 the church clock struck and the phone buzzed on the dashboard. Up in the bucket Kévin let go of the string and held his left hand in front of his face. He touched each finger in turn with his right hand, moving his lips. Then he picked up the string again.

‘What are you counting?’ she called up.

‘Fingers.’ He leaned on the edge of the bucket. ‘It’s a thing you can learn, waking up inside your dreams. The phone goes off on the hour and you count. Five, and you’re awake. In a dream the hand comes out wrong. Six, or seven, or they won’t keep still. Then you know, and you can do what you like. I want to fly. As high as the church. Is that stupid?’

‘And if you lie down and you can’t move?’

‘With something sitting on you? I’ve had that twice, wide awake. I pushed it off both times. I was so scared. Have you?’

‘I pushed,’ she said. ‘With a cracked rib.’

‘The thing on your chest is the way in,’ K vin said. ‘Don’t push it off. Lie still under it and you’re in the dream, wide awake.’

* * *

Coralie was on the late shift. She had said once that the old woman in room twelve talked every night to something on top of her wardrobe. Maylis wanted to hear what was said to it. So at 9:45 that night she drove down to the Port to pick Coralie up.

The care home had its night lights on and the lamp lit over the back door. Coralie was in the corridor, at the end nearest the bank. She was standing outside the last door in her work uniform, with her arms folded. The door had the number twelve on it. It wasn’t quite shut.

‘Two minutes,’ Coralie said quietly. ‘I can’t go till she’s done. It’s in the care plan.’

‘What is?’

‘Listen.’

Inside, the old woman was speaking slowly to somebody.

‘Inguma, enauk hire beldur.’

‘That’s Madame Etcheto. She’s ninety-four. She says that every night to a thing that sits on her chest. The words mean she’s not afraid of it.’ Coralie put her mouth to Maylis’s ear. ‘Now she gives it its work.’

‘You’ll count the stars,’ the voice said. ‘The ones behind the cloud as well. You’re not to come till you’ve finished.’

‘Does it work?’ Maylis whispered.

‘Till 3,’ Coralie said. ‘Then it comes anyway, and Madame Etcheto rings her bell for us.’

A boy with a mop was standing at the far end of the corridor. He stayed where he was.

‘That’s Bixente. He drives the minibus. He got his Basque from his grandmother, and in his first week he said the words along with Madame Etcheto, through the door, to be friendly. She reported him. She said he had made it lose its count, and it came at 1 instead of 3.’ Coralie’s shoulders had started to shake. ‘It’s in the plan now. Staff to wait. Staff not to join in.’

Maylis laughed. The rib caught the laugh and turned it into a bark.

‘Who’s that at my door?’

Coralie pushed the door open.

‘It’s Coralie, Madame Etcheto. And Maylis, who’s come to take me home. She’s the one who repaired the lamp over the back door, and she’ll tell you she didn’t.’

Madame Etcheto was lying against two pillows with her hands on top of the blanket, facing her wardrobe. Her eyes went to the arm Maylis held across her side and stayed there.

‘The village’s girl,’ Madame Etcheto said. ‘Your father dug my husband’s grave.’ Her voice was strong. ‘You were laughing.’

‘It was the rib.’

‘A rib doesn’t laugh. What’s wrong with it?’

‘She cracked it on Monday,’ Coralie said. ‘She has to sleep on her back. And on Tuesday at 3 in the morning she was awake with a pulse of 112, and she tells me that was the rib as well.’

‘Where did you sleep before Monday?’

‘On my side. At the edge.’

Madame Etcheto nodded.

‘That’s Inguma. It has a name, so use it. What do you have a great many of?’

‘Leaves,’ Maylis said. ‘In the square. Two trailers a week.’

‘Give it those. Go on. I’ve said mine.’

Maylis looked at Coralie. Coralie had stopped laughing.

‘It has to count the leaves in the square,’ Maylis said.

‘Before it comes,’ said Madame Etcheto.

‘Before it comes.’

‘That will do for one night.’ Madame Etcheto shut her eyes. ‘It hasn’t come for you, girl. It comes to your bed. You’ve been lying where it sits since Monday, and you’ve given it nothing to count. My mother told me the rest. Some nights it takes the sleeper away with it and leaves her body in the bed. Before morning it takes her home. The one it cannot take home dies in that bed.’

She opened her eyes.

‘After that she plays bingo with the rest of the dead.’

‘With cards?’ Coralie said.

‘A card of numbers each, and grains of corn to mark it. They lay a place for her at their table.’

‘You said it comes to Maylis’s bed. I’m in that bed too,’ Coralie said. ‘When has it ever sat on me?’

* * *

That night, on her back in bed, Maylis said the words quietly to the top of the wardrobe.

‘Inguma, enauk hire beldur.’

It sounded like something she was reading off a label.

In room twelve she had given Inguma the leaves in the square. But she had raked the square that afternoon, right down to the drain covers.

That left the stars, which Madame Etcheto gave it herself. Maylis could give it the ones she could see, or the ones behind the cloud as well.

‘Either,’ Maylis said.

At its usual minute Inguma came down off the wardrobe and landed on the floor.

* * *

On Friday evening Maylis opened the top drawer of the chest of drawers and took out the envelope. It had been

in there since the June of the steel room. The glue had held.

That morning she had woken with a third picture in her head. This one was grey water. It didn't move. It was where the flood fields should have been, from the foot of the bank to the far trees. None of the three pictures was hers. But the first had her name in it, over a date that was fifteen days away now. And that steel box had been built to find out whether there were two of her.

She remembered which lamp had come on. She cut the envelope open with her pocket knife and pulled out the card.

left

That was the lamp she had seen. She put the card in the chest pocket of her raincoat.

At 2:50 that night she counted her fingers. Five. When Inguma came she didn't push. Somebody had been under there with her since Tuesday night, and she wanted to know who.

Then she was in the chair in the steel room. The arms of the chair were warm, though she hadn't been sitting there long enough to warm them. She counted her fingers again. Five.

The panel was in front of her, with both its lamps lit. On a shelf under the panel was a brown envelope, with the card pulled half out of it.

right

It was in her own handwriting.

A long way off, Coralie's alarm rang. Maylis got up out of the seat. Somebody was still sitting in it.

Then she saw the lampshade and felt two fingers on the inside of her wrist. Her left hand came across and closed over Coralie's fingers. Maylis hadn't told it to.

'Come back across. I've left you on that landing eleven years,' her mouth said.

3

Lesca, the mayor, was lying on her back in a bed that wasn't hers, listening to the rain on the roof. The room could have been her own. The paper lampshade: hers. The top of the wardrobe: hers. The clock radio, 06:00 in red: hers. The rain: not hers. No rain had fallen on her own roof for two weeks. Pillows: two. At home she had one. On the back of the door hung a yellow raincoat with COMMUNE DE PEYREBARTHE across its shoulders. She had handed that coat in with her keys when she became mayor.

She breathed in, and a rib caught on the right side. There was nothing wrong with her own ribs.

A minute earlier she had been asleep in a steel chair, with somebody warm sitting in it beside her. Then an alarm had rung a long way off. The warmth had got up to go. Lesca had stayed sitting, and had gone with it.

Coralie was lying between her and the wall, warm from the bed, with her hair flat on one side. She reached across Lesca to stop the alarm. At home that alarm rang on the other side of the landing.

Coralie sat up, lifted the right wrist off the blanket, put two fingers on the inside of it and watched the clock radio.

'Your pulse is 130,' she said. 'You were lying there with your eyes open again. What is it this time?'

An answer went past Lesca on its way to the mouth. It was about the rib, and it wasn't hers. Maylis was in here too, and she was about to say it.

Lesca got in first. She told the left hand to move and it moved. She brought it across and closed it over Coralie's fingers.

They were warm, and rough at the tips from the soap at work. Under Coralie's fingers the right wrist began to pull away. Lesca wasn't the one pulling. Maylis was. Lesca held on with the left hand while the pull went up the right arm and into the cracked rib.

'Maylis?' Coralie said.

Lesca told the mouth to open. It was stiff, but it was hers to use.

'Come back across. I've left you on that landing eleven years.'

The voice came out low.

Coralie kept her fingers where they were, on the pulse.

‘Across what?’ she said. ‘I’m here. I’m in the bed.’ She was looking at the mouth. ‘And you don’t ask. You’ve never once asked me for anything. I’d have come for half that sentence, from the far end of the Port. Where did you get eleven?’

She bent down and looked into one eye, then into the other. Then she took her fingers back. She had to pull to get them.

‘Who is that?’

She got out of the bed and stood beside it, holding her fingers in her other hand.

Lesca opened the mouth to tell her, but the jaw was pulled out of her hold.

‘The rib,’ the mouth said, in a voice higher than Lesca’s.

Two words were all Maylis could get out before Lesca had the jaw back. By then the jaw was no use to Lesca. The room had gone cold. The thing was on the chest with its back to her, just as it had been on her own chest every night for twelve years. It took her home.

She was in her own bed, under a dry roof. Clock radio: 06:20. Pillows: one. Coralie was coming around the bed in her dressing gown with the phone in her hand. The thing got down.

‘Twenty minutes,’ this Coralie said. ‘Lie still. Your eyes were open and I couldn’t wake you, so I’ve rung your mother. Give me that wrist, Madame le maire.’

She took it between a finger and thumb and watched the clock. Lesca let her have it.

‘It’s 90, and coming down.’ She laid the wrist back on the blanket. In this village she ran the care home in the Port.

She was at the door when Lesca said her name.

‘Madame le maire?’

Lesca had the sentence ready. This was the woman it was for.

‘Nothing. Go back to bed.’

The spare room was four steps away, across the landing. Coralie had carried her pillow over there in the February after the flood, and the pillow had stayed. The door shut.

Lesca was lying in the middle of the bed with her left hand closed.

In June 2014 the woman from the university had asked her whether, somewhere, she also saw the other lamp. Somewhere was another Peyrebarthe.

So she could cross.

* * *

There was a white frost on the square that morning. Lesca left her car by the church and crossed on foot. She had no parking space, because the one in front of the town hall door had been given to the stone.

The stone faced the square, so most days she walked past the back of it. That Saturday she went around to the front. The top line was JEAN CASTAGNET, who had been Jean in the town hall's files and Jeannot at the café. Under him, in the same capitals, was MAYLIS LESCA. Under that was the date. There was frost in the bottom of each letter.

He had drowned on the night of the flood. In his whole life he had sent the town hall twelve letters. But something had come home with her from that bed, the way mud comes home on a boot. She remembered signing for a registered letter from him on Tuesday, in the rain, with a rake in her other hand. It was his forty-first. Lesca hadn't held a rake since she handed in the coat.

Over there he was alive and still writing.

She didn't trust it. She had wanted him alive for twelve years, and she had nothing to check it against.

She stood in front of the top line with her keys in her hand and read his name through to the last letter before she went in.

In the council room the committee for the twelfth commemoration of the flood had got as far as Larrère, who had asked to speak. Marie-Jo Labat turned a white kitchen timer to three and stood it in front of him. Any member could speak for three minutes on any item. Lesca had made that rule in her first month as mayor. It was for Larrère, who had been mayor before her.

Larrère used his three minutes to explain floodgates to Lesca across the table.

'A gate is a door in a bank, Madame le maire. It is not a tap. You don't turn it on because the sink's full.'

The timer rang while he was in the middle of the word hydraulic. He finished the word and laid a hand flat on the table.

Lesca answered him, as she did at that table every year.

‘A door in a bank is opened from the platform, Guy, and I was the one on the platform. The bank had ten minutes left. Behind it were forty houses, and the care home, with forty-two people in their beds. Out on the fields there was one man, at his duck hut, and no one came to tell him. I opened it. Behind the bank, nobody even woke up.’

It took her half a minute. Nobody at that table had ever asked her a question about it. Maïté Castagnet, Jean’s widow, held her handbag in front of her with both hands and looked at the radiator.

The last item was the stone. Marie-Jo stood the timer in front of Larrère again.

‘I propose that the stone be given a verb,’ he said. ‘It has a man’s name and a woman’s name and nothing between them. A stranger reads it as a married couple. I propose Saved.’

‘Saved who?’ Marie-Jo said. She hadn’t spoken to Lesca directly since 2018, so she said it to the wall above Lesca’s head. ‘Castagnet, Saved, Lesca. It reads as if he was saved, by her.’

‘Opened.’

‘Opened what? Castagnet, Opened. It reads as if he was opened.’

‘I have a verb,’ Maïté said.

Every head turned. At that table she had never said anything except that she abstained. She opened her mouth to say the verb.

The timer rang.

‘That’s the member’s time,’ Marie-Jo said, to the wall. ‘It goes to the vote.’

Larrère’s verb lost the vote, as it had every time before. Lesca voted against it. Her left hand went up still closed. She had to open it to be counted.

Maïté waited until the others had their coats on.

‘Did you know he was out?’ she said.

‘No one came to tell him,’ Lesca said.

‘Yes. You said— At the table, you said that.’ Maïté did up the top button of her coat. ‘There’s a tile gone over the back bedroom. Right over the wardrobe.’

‘I’ll come at 2, while there’s light.’

* * *

The Castagnet house stood on the edge of the high ground above the Port. Lesca had looked after its roof since the January after the flood, though no council vote had ever asked her to.

That afternoon Maïté stood in her black coat and held the bottom of the ladder while Lesca set the tile back in its row and cleared the leaves out of the gutter along the roof. She was nearly down again when Maïté spoke.

‘It was raining by now, that year. It started in the night, and I had his rubber boots drying by the stove every evening after that.’

‘On the 24th. It’s in the file.’

Lesca stopped on the ladder. It was white with frost under her hands. Peyrebarthe had been dry for two weeks. But that morning she had been in a bed with rain falling on the roof. And on Tuesday, over there, the ink had run on the card she signed.

Tuesday had been the 24th.

She came down the last steps, laid the ladder along the wall, drove to the town hall and let herself in. She took the flood file for 2014 down from the cupboard and opened it on her desk at the pages where the height of the river was written down.

She had been the keyholder that winter. Every day she had gone down to the old gate, where her father had painted a red line on the pillar at the height of the doorsteps in the Port. She had read the river against that line and written down what she saw, one line a day. Now she read those lines with a finger under each.

24 November 2014. Under the line. Rain since the night.

25 November 2014. Under the line. Rain.

26 November 2014. Under the line. Rain.

27 November 2014. Under the line. Rain.

28 November 2014. Under the line. Rain.

Today was the 28th.

Ever since she stood at the stone that morning, she had taken the other village for the lucky one. Its river had stayed behind its bank in 2014, so its Castagnet had lived. But the rain over there had started in the night before the 24th, exactly as it had in her file. Four lines later it was still falling.

That village hadn't had its flood yet.

She turned the page and went on down the dates. On 8 December 2014 the river had reached the line. Three lines later she came to the last one in her own handwriting.

11 December 2014, 22:00. Over the line. Rising.

Under that the file was typed, by the gendarmes.

First light. CASTAGNET Jean recovered from the cellar of his duck hut. Trapdoor locked on the inside. Watch stopped at 03:11.

This year the 11th fell on a Friday, thirteen days away. That night the river over there would be at the top of the bank, with Castagnet out at his hut. Larrère would ring Maylis, as he had rung Lesca, and tell her to keep the gate shut. Maylis had the key, but only Lesca had the date.

She couldn't get Jean Castagnet out of his cellar. But over there he was still above ground, and she wanted to keep him there.

She took a sheet of the town hall's paper from the drawer. When something had to be decided, the only form she had for it was a motion. So she wrote the heading for one. That morning she had stayed sitting, and she had woken up over there with a mouth. A mouth could tell that village what was coming, during office hours.

She wrote the motion under the heading.

That the mayor remain seated.

It didn't say for how long. That morning the thing had come for her after twenty minutes. She wanted a day.

* * *

When it got dark Lesca crossed the yard to her mother's kitchen and asked her question before she sat down.

'The thing that sits on a sleeper. What did your mother give it to count, and how long did that keep it off her?'

Arlette was at the stove. 'My mother had words for everything. She had some for the stove, and a whole set for the priest that she only used after he'd gone.' She turned the potatoes. 'For Inguma she had the grass on the village field. She gave it that, blade by blade, and it was counting till daylight. Madame Etcheto, down in the Port, gives it the stars. Coralie tells me the old woman rings for the night staff at 3. Stars, in winter, under cloud. It needs more than that. A great many things, and small ones.'

'I want a day. A whole one, and a Monday. On a Sunday the town hall is shut, and there'd be nobody to tell.'

Arlette put the pan down.

‘Nobody gives it that much just to sleep, Maylis.’

Her mother had never called her anything else.

* * *

When Lesca came in, Coralie had the soup on and two places laid at the kitchen table.

‘Madame le maire will sit down,’ she said, ‘and eat it while it’s hot.’

‘I’ll have it here. I’ve got the minutes of this morning’s meeting to read.’

‘It’s soup. It doesn’t need a vote.’

Lesca ate it standing at the stove, with the minutes open beside the pan.

At 10 they went up. At the top of the stairs there were two bedroom doors, with the landing between them.

‘Good night, Madame le maire,’ Coralie said, and shut hers.

Lesca left her own door open and got into the middle of the bed. From there she could see the light under Coralie’s door. That morning she had held Coralie’s fingers, in Maylis’s hand. Before that she hadn’t held them since a February eleven years earlier.

When the light went out she got up, went down to the kitchen and unfolded the sheet of paper on the table.

That the mayor remain seated.

A motion is supposed to say what it is for. This one kept that back. She had sent Larrère’s motions back down the table for less.

She changed the full stop to a comma and went on in the same ink to the end of the line.

That the mayor remain seated, and take the other one’s bed, and Coralie Mounet in it.

It was breakfast that same Saturday, in Maylis's kitchen, with rain on the window. Coralie stood in her work uniform with the coffee pot in her hand. She gave Maylis back the whole sentence from 6 that morning, in the voice she used for reading a dose off a chart.

'That's what I heard,' she said. 'I said it over to myself on the stairs, so I wouldn't lose it. Was that you?'

Maylis opened her mouth and had nothing to put in it.

Coralie put the pot down.

'Then I'll tell you what it is at work,' she said. 'You haven't slept a night through since Monday, and you're on your back for the rib. That's how it starts. The head wakes up before the body does. The eyes are open, nothing will move, and there's a weight on the chest. Madame Etcheto calls it Inguma. The doctor calls it sleep paralysis, and half the night staff have had it.' She laid her hand on Maylis's. 'And people who don't sleep say things. We had a man in room six who didn't sleep for a week after his wife died. On the last morning he told me to bring the horses around, in a voice I'd never heard out of him. He'd never owned a horse. By lunch he was asking who had been shouting in his room.'

Maylis wanted that to be all it was: a rib, five bad nights and a word the doctor had for it. Then the stone was a dream, and the date on it was only a date. For as long as Coralie's hand was on hers, she believed it.

'He asked for horses, though,' Coralie said. 'You asked for me.'

She took her hand away, pulled the shopping pad across the table and wrote the sentence out on it, pressing hard. Under it she drew two boxes. She wrote *You* beside one and *Somebody else* beside the other. Then she turned the pad around and put the pencil on top of it. 'Tick one.'

Maylis picked up the pencil in her left hand. Both answers were true. There was no third box.

She ticked both.

'It's what I've got,' she said.

'Then I'll tell you what I've got. You held my hand. You put yours over it and held on, and I can't remember the last time you did that. And the whole time, your wrist was trying to get out from under my fingers. I felt both. I've held hands for a living since I was twenty, so I know when a hand is holding on, and I know when it

wants to be let go.' Coralie put a finger on each box. 'So which one was you? The holding, or the getting away?'

The getting away was hers. She could hear how that would sound, said across the table to Coralie. The holding on belonged to somebody else. Maylis wished it had been hers.

'I was slow waking up,' she said.

'You were wide awake, with a pulse of 130.' Coralie took her finger off *You* and left the other on *Somebody else*. 'I've waited a long time to be asked for one thing in this house. This morning somebody asks me, out loud, holding my hand. And it's about a landing I've never slept across, with the wrong number of years in it, and you can't tell me who did the asking.'

'No.'

Coralie waited. She had the early shift to get to, but she took her time over her coat.

Then she tore the page off the pad, folded it and put it in her coat pocket. On her way to the door she reached behind the fruit bowl and took out an envelope that had been standing there since March. She put it in her bag.

* * *

That night Maylis kept still under Inguma again. She wanted to see who had held Coralie's hand. Then she was in the chair in the steel room. She stood up.

The warmth along her back stayed where it was. She took a step towards the panel and turned around.

Lesca was sitting in the chair, in Maylis's T-shirt. She had Maylis's hands too, on the steel arms of the chair, the left one open now and the right one closed in a fist. She sat much straighter than Maylis did. There was nothing wrong with her ribs.

'Good,' Lesca said. 'You can get up. That saves a week. I have a number of things to tell you, and I was starting to think I'd have to say them through your mouth, which is no way to do business. I found that out this morning. Sit down.'

'There's only one chair.'

'Then I'll stand.' Lesca stood up. 'A meeting needs somebody in the chair. Since neither of us is in it, I'll chair from here. The first item is who I am. Maylis Lesca, mayor of Peyrebarthe.'

'We've got a mayor. He sits in his car.'

'Not in my village. In mine he sits at my table, and I time him. In June 2014 I sat in this chair and the right

lamp came on.'

'The left,' Maylis said. Both were lit now, on the panel behind her. 'They asked whether I also saw the other one.'

'You're looking at her.'

'I had a stone,' Maylis said. 'With my name on it. And a square full of people.'

'Both mine. I got a rake, and a postman. The second item is Monday. This morning I had twenty minutes in your bed before Inguma fetched me home. On Monday I'm having the day. All those in favour.'

'There are two of us,' Maylis said.

'Then it's carried, or it's a tie, and in a tie the chair decides.'

'There's nobody in the chair.'

'Next item,' Lesca said. 'Which do you want first? What I've come about, or what happened at 6 this morning?'

Maylis opened her mouth to say Either.

'Don't.' Lesca's fist closed tighter. 'Not in here. I gave that word up when I was thirty-one, and I won't have my own face say it to me.'

Maylis had written *Either* on the shopping pad on Tuesday, when she wanted the duck.

'This morning at 6,' she said. 'I want that first. You held Coralie's hand.'

'With your hand,' Lesca said. 'She put two fingers on your wrist, and I took them.'

'With my mouth,' Maylis said. 'Eleven years. I don't know anything about eleven years.'

'No. That's an item for another night. Listen to me now, because this is what I came over for. The stone you saw stands in front of my town hall. It isn't a grave. It's for a night.'

Maylis had been counting the days to the 12th since Tuesday. For one breath she didn't have to.

Then Lesca told her about the night, in order. Jean Castagnet's name was cut above theirs. He had drowned in the cellar of his duck hut on the night of 11 December 2014, on the eighteenth day of rain. The 12th was the morning they got him out. Afterwards his eel nets were found under the floor of the hut, green and folded wet.

'It's rained here since Tuesday,' Maylis said.

‘Since the 24th. I know it has. Your river is where my file says it was, day for day. On Friday the 11th, at night, your river will be ninety centimetres over your father’s red line, and water will be coming through the bank beside the last house in the Port.’

‘We had a dry winter here in 2014,’ Maylis said. ‘I was cutting roadsides in December. Why would it come now?’

‘Your mayor is Larrère, and he sits on the association’s money,’ Lesca said. ‘There’s a handle that sticks at nineteen turns, and three letters about it in the minutes. It comes because nobody has looked after your bank for twelve years.’

‘I have,’ Maylis said. ‘I patched it beside that last house in April, one wheelbarrow at a time. And I wrote those three letters.’

Lesca’s fist opened and closed.

‘Then why does it come?’ Maylis said.

‘I don’t know why it comes.’

‘Then stop coming,’ Maylis said. ‘You’ve got a date and no reason for it, and this morning you had my mouth. Stay in your own bed.’

‘I can’t. Inguma has sat on me every night for twelve years, and I’ve never kept it off. I stopped trying in the first month.’ Lesca looked at the arm Maylis held across her side. ‘You pushed it off, the first nights. I felt you do it. That rib will tell you how many more nights you can push.’

Maylis took a breath to answer and the rib caught on it.

‘Last item, then,’ Lesca said, ‘and it’s the one I want you to remember. That floodgate is opened on Friday afternoon. In daylight, while the tide is going out, by order, with the fields cleared and nobody on them. And nobody stands on a platform in the dark and chooses.’

‘Whose order?’

‘Larrère’s. He’s the president of the association that owns that gate, and nobody else can give it. On Monday I’m coming over to ask him, in office hours.’

‘An order is a signature,’ Maylis said. ‘It took that town hall three letters to take note of a handle. This order lets a river onto every man’s corn in broad daylight. That costs more than I can pay.’

‘Then I’ll pay it. I sign things.’

‘There’s no word on your stone?’ Maylis said. ‘Between Jeannot and us?’

‘The council debated it three times.’

‘What would the word be?’

Lesca didn’t answer.

The door of the box opened. It had rubber around its edge and no handle. Inguma came in with the sound of a sack being dragged, crossed the steel floor between them and turned its back on each of them as it passed. Then it climbed into the empty chair.

Maylis was lying on her back in her own bed, with rain on the roof.

She believed the date. She wanted that gate opened on Friday afternoon as much as Lesca did. What scared her was Monday, when her own mouth would say so to Larrère, who paid her.

* * *

On Sunday morning Maylis found she couldn’t look at Jeannot.

She went to the café at 10 for bread, which the café sold from a crate on the counter. Jeannot was on his stool in his jacket, with his glass in front of him. She crossed the room looking at the crate, stopped beside him and put her money down.

‘Little Lesca,’ he said.

‘Jeannot.’

Out of the corner of her eye she could see his hand on the counter. She tried to lift her eyes up his sleeve to his face, but they wouldn’t go past his wrist.

‘On Tuesday you signed for my letter,’ he said. ‘And now you won’t look at a man. What have I done?’

‘Nothing.’

‘Then look at me when you say it.’

She looked at his boots.

‘One,’ Jeannot said. ‘Those are my boots.’

Lesca had told her how he drowned. None of that had happened in this café, but her neck didn’t know that. She wanted to tell him to stay off the fields on the 11th. The only reason she could give him was a dream.

She had passed the flowers on her way in. Josiane, the owner's wife, kept the pots left over from All Saints' Day outside the door, at a reduced price. Maylis took her bread, went out and picked up a pot of bronze chrysanthemums by its edge. They had a week left in them. She had gone back in and paid for them before she knew what she was doing.

'Who's dead?' said old Bordenave, from the card table.

She had no answer. Jeannot turned on his stool to look.

'Two,' Jeannot said.

She went out with the bread under her arm and the pot in her left hand. She crossed the square in front of the café window and took the road along the edge of the high ground. That road led to four houses and no graves. The café watched her go. Jeannot lived in the fourth house.

Marie-Jo was coming down the church steps with a bucket of dead flowers. There was no Mass in Peyrebarthe that Sunday. On Sundays like that she did the vases. She stopped on the bottom step.

'Those are chrysanthemums.'

'Yes.'

'You're four weeks late for All Saints, or you're early for somebody,' Marie-Jo said. 'Where are you going with them?'

'To Maïté Castagnet.'

'With him sitting in the café? Somebody should go in and tell him he's dead.'

Marie-Jo stayed on the bottom step with her bucket. Maylis felt Marie-Jo watching the pot all the way to the fourth house.

* * *

Maïté opened her door in a blue dressing gown, with a potato in one hand and a knife in the other. She looked at the pot before she looked at Maylis.

'Has something happened to him?'

'No,' Maylis said. 'He's at the café.'

'Then who are those for?'

‘For you.’

Maïté looked up from the flowers at Maylis’s face. Maylis could feel the look on her own face, the one people give a woman beside a grave. She couldn’t get it off. Maïté took a step back from it.

‘You’d better come in,’ Maïté said. ‘Before the street sees.’

She took the pot and walked once around the kitchen with it. In the end she put it in the sink, on top of the potato peelings.

From where Maylis stood she could see the rack beside the sink. Two bowls were drying on it, with two spoons. On the cupboard, next to the bread, was a cardboard folder with one darker patch where rain had got at it. On wet days Larrère held that folder over his head between his car and the town hall door.

Maïté moved the bread on top of it.

‘Jeannot comes up from the fields at first light, and he’s at that counter by 8,’ she said, with her back turned. ‘On a Sunday I don’t see him until his lunch is on the table. It’s been like that since I got married.’ She turned around. ‘And now the village is on my doorstep with a pot of flowers. What does it want?’

That was when Maylis found out what she had come to say. The night before, in the chair, before she stood up, she had been given one of Lesca’s afternoons. In it she was on a ladder at the back of this house with a roof tile in her hand. Maïté was holding the bottom of the ladder, dressed in black.

‘Your back gutter. Over the bedroom. Is water coming in?’

Maïté went still.

‘Since October. It runs down the inside wall and onto the wardrobe, so there’s a basin up there. He says he’ll see to it when the duck season’s over.’ Her eyes had narrowed. ‘Who told you about my gutter? No. It’s Josiane. She’s never been past my gate, and she— It’s Josiane.’

‘Nobody. I could fix it. There’s a ladder at the shed.’ It was half an hour’s work.

‘With that rib? On a Sunday?’ Maïté laughed once. ‘The village’s girl up my wall, and those in my sink, and him at the— No. I’d never hear the end of it.’

‘I’m sorry,’ Maylis said.

‘What for?’

She had no reason she could give for it. Past Maïté, at the end of the passage, the bedroom door was half open. On top of the wardrobe a metal basin stood under a brown stain on the ceiling. Beside it was a light brown

suitcase with both its straps done up, the only thing up there with no dust on it.

Maïté saw where Maylis was looking. She went down the passage, pulled the door shut and came back.

‘That’s winter things,’ she said. ‘In the— It’s blankets.’

At the front door Maylis bent down and kissed her on the cheek. Maïté kept her face still for it. Then she stood in her doorway with her hands in the pockets of the dressing gown.

‘You looked at me just now as if I’d buried somebody,’ she said. ‘People looked at me like that at my mother’s funeral. If you see me in the square, don’t— Not there.’

* * *

On Sunday night Maylis could have pushed, but she kept still. Keeping Lesca out meant having a better plan, and Maylis didn’t have one. Somebody had to tell the village. She would rather it was Lesca, who signed things. The chair was warm. She didn’t turn around to look, because that meant another meeting.

At 6 on Monday morning she woke up. Her legs swung out of the bed and carried her down to the kitchen.

Maylis let her mouth speak without her.

‘I want Larrère in my office at 9.’

Coralie had just come down in her uniform. The voice was Lesca’s, lower than Maylis’s own.

‘In your what?’

‘At the town hall, then, if he prefers.’

‘You’ve got a shed, Maylis. It has a lawnmower in it.’ Coralie had stopped with the coffee pot in her hand.

The shopping pad was on the table. Under *Tonight* it said *soup*, then *omelette*, with an empty box drawn beside each. Lesca picked up the pencil with the left hand, ticked *soup* and wrote 7 after it. Two seconds.

Coralie put the pot down and turned the pad around.

‘One,’ she said. ‘With a time on it.’ When she looked up she was close to laughing. ‘So I’ve got soup. What else do you want? Go on. Give me the rest.’

Lesca had the rest ready. Maylis felt the chest fill for it, as deep as the cracked rib would let it. Maylis got to the mouth first.

‘Either,’ she said.

Coralie let her breath out.

‘For a minute there I had somebody,’ she said. She took her keys off the hook. ‘Don’t rub the tick out. I want to find it there at 7.’

The front door had hardly shut behind her when the kitchen went cold. Something heavy came up against the kitchen door from the outside and stopped there.

Lesca turned the head towards the door and spoke to it out loud.

‘Inguma, enauk hire beldur. In my village there’s a lake where the village field was. You’ll count the stones the gravel company took out of it. You’re not to come till you’ve finished.’

The weight moved off the door and the cold went with it.

‘That’s a day,’ Lesca said to the right hand, which was still Maylis’s.

* * *

At 8 Lesca walked her down through the Port in the rain, to the last house. Sarthou, the gendarme, lived in it.

The patch Maylis repaired every spring was in the bank above his roof. It had turned dark across the width of a door. It was supposed to last until spring. The rain had washed some of the clay down over the road, and Sarthou was out there with a shovel.

‘That is the village’s clay,’ he said. ‘I have removed it from my gate twice since 7.’

By Maylis’s count he had half a wheelbarrow there. Lesca walked her up onto the bank, to the platform of the floodgate.

‘On Friday the 11th, if nobody orders this gate up in the afternoon, somebody has to turn it at night,’ Lesca said out loud, to the right hand. ‘I want to know if these arms can do that alone.’

Lesca unlocked the box with the key from the belt, fitted the handle and began to turn it with the left hand. The chain came up wet. Lesca counted the clicks of the catch, the steel tooth that stopped the chain running back. At eighteen, the bottom of the gate was ten centimetres clear of the stone it rested on.

At the nineteenth the handle stopped.

‘Here it needs a shoulder and both arms, and I have one,’ Lesca said. ‘Give me the other.’

Maylis kept her right arm where it was, across her side.

The left shoulder went under the handle and the legs pushed.

The handle gave all at once. The catch slipped, the gate dropped on its chain and the handle came spinning back. It was Maylis’s gate, and it was falling. Her right hand went out before she had decided anything. It closed on the handle, which ran on through her fist until Lesca got the left hand to it and stopped it.

Maylis opened her hand in the rain. The skin was gone in one straight line, from the base of the forefinger to the bottom of the palm.

Lesca kept the eyes on it longer than a cut deserved.

‘I have that,’ Lesca said. ‘The same hand and the same line. I got mine the night I raised this gate.’ The left hand let the gate down one click at a time and locked the handle in its box. ‘So one arm won’t do it. On the

Friday I'll need both of yours, and you'll have to give me the right one.'

* * *

At 9 Maylis was standing beside the village van, in front of the town hall, where Lesca had stopped her. Larrère pulled up next to the van and lowered his window a few centimetres.

'The lights,' he said through the gap. 'Your father switched them on at 5. At 5 this year, or at 6?'

Maylis had answered that gap with the same word for eighteen years. He was already closing the window on it. She felt the mouth get ready for the word.

Lesca stopped it. The mouth tried again.

'Ei—' it said. Lesca cut it off. 'You have three minutes.'

The window stopped. Maylis still had her right hand, wrapped in a handkerchief. She held it up to the gap with the palm open, to say sorry for the mouth.

'I have what?'

'Three minutes on any item, Guy. You've spent some of them on my father. I'll spend the rest on what you should be asking me. On Tuesday the 8th that river is at the red line. The prefecture at Pau sends you a yellow warning. You'll stop this car at the café door and tell me that the gate stays shut, and that people in the Port know they live by a river. Three nights later the river comes through the bank at the last house. So on that Friday afternoon you'll order the gate raised, in daylight, while the tide is going out, with the fields cleared.'

The window went down. It went all the way down, into the door. Maylis hadn't known it could.

He let the rain fall on his sleeve.

'What did she tell you?'

'Who?'

'Madame Castagnet,' Larrère said. 'Twenty minutes in her kitchen yesterday, with flowers, they tell me. And this morning the village's girl knows what I'm going to say on a Tuesday.' His voice was steady again. 'Guy, she calls me, in my own square. You'll stay away from that house. And this morning goes into your file, with the time on it.'

The window went up, all the way.

* * *

At noon Lesca walked her into the café.

Jeannot was on his stool at the counter with a glass in front of him. He had mud drying on his rubber boots. He was scratching his ear.

The legs stopped inside the door. The eyes had gone to the back of his neck, and Lesca left them there. Maylis had stood beside that neck at this counter for eighteen years without once looking at it. It was red from the weather and it needed a barber. She felt the breath stop in the chest and start again.

‘Still in the box, were you?’ the dealer said. He didn’t look up from his cards. It was what the café had said to anybody who came in late, ever since the June of the steel room. ‘The bread went at 11.’

‘For three hours,’ Lesca said. ‘On 12 June 2014, from 2 until 5. I’ve been on time ever since. I came at noon because you’re all here at noon.’

The cards went down.

Jeannot turned around on his stool, glass in hand.

The eyes wouldn’t leave him. Maylis could feel her own face smiling at him.

‘What?’ Jeannot said. ‘Have I got something on me?’

The mouth opened and nothing came. When Lesca did find something to say to him, it was an old bill out of Maylis’s memory.

‘You owe the village a tank of diesel. Its tractor pulled your van out of the track, in January 2017.’

‘And left two wheel tracks in it. That’s my letter seventeen. The village was sent the bill.’

The face went on smiling while he argued.

‘She’s been like this since 9,’ old Bordenave said. He kept the café’s score pad. He turned it over to the clean side. ‘I saw Larrère’s window go down. Right down. What did you tell him? Say it slowly.’

‘What he’ll say to me on Tuesday the 8th, at that door. That the river’s at the line, that the gate stays shut, and that people in the Port know they live by a river.’

Bordenave wrote it down and put the date beside it.

‘The 8th’s a week off,’ the dealer said. ‘Give Bordenave one for this week.’

‘Friday the 4th, in the morning. The river is seventy under the line.’

‘She’s got a mayor in her,’ the dealer said. ‘Put that at the top.’

Bordenave printed *Madame le Maire* across the top of the page and underlined it. Then he turned the pad around for her to see.

‘It takes a small m,’ Lesca said. Bordenave went over the M and made it a small one.

Then Lesca turned the face to the room. Maylis heard the voice settle.

‘On the night of Friday the 11th that river comes through the bank at the Port. Behind the bank there are forty houses, and the care home. And out on the fields, in his duck hut, there is one man—’

‘One man,’ Josiane said from behind the counter. ‘She’s said it herself. One man, and she can’t take her eyes off him, and she knows by heart the month she towed him, and yesterday she’s up at his wife’s with a pot of flowers off my doorstep. A woman takes flowers to the wife because she’s after the husband or because she’s after the wife. It’s adultery whichever she’s after, and it’s in that house.’

‘Which do I put?’ Bordenave said.

‘The husband,’ Josiane said. ‘She lives with a nurse, and that’s to throw us off.’

‘One man,’ Jeannot said, and got down off his stool. ‘That’s me she’s got out there.’

‘Go down to your hut tonight if you have to,’ Lesca said. ‘On Friday the 11th you stay in your kitchen. I forbid you to go.’

‘Nobody at that town hall has ever answered me, and now it forbids me,’ Jeannot said. ‘I hadn’t given the 11th a thought until you handed it to me.’ He stopped beside her on his way to the door. He smelled of his stove and of tall wet grass. ‘I’m giving it one now.’

Lesca had no answer for that. Maylis felt the mouth hang open, and she took it.

‘Put it in forty-two,’ she said, in her own voice.

He looked at the face.

‘Forty-two’s started,’ Jeannot said. ‘You’re on its second page.’

He went out into the rain.

* * *

At 7 there was soup, because soup had been ticked.

Maylis sat in her own chair with her right hand beside the bowl, wrapped in a clean dish towel. That hand wouldn't hold a shovel for a week. Lesca held the spoon in the left. Coralie served the soup and sat down across the table.

'By 10 they knew at work that you'd given Larrère three minutes,' Coralie said. 'What did he do?'

'He lowered his window, to the bottom. He has talked to this village through a gap since 2008. It took his first name to get the glass out of the way.'

Coralie put her head back and laughed. Then she looked across the table for the other half of the laugh.

Maylis got that laugh out of her three or four times a year. Lesca didn't know there was another half.

'By 2 we had the flowers as well,' Coralie said. She was still smiling. 'Chrysanthemums, up to Maïté Castagnet's door on a Sunday, and today you couldn't take your eyes off her husband. Josiane says it has to be one of them.' She put her spoon down. 'So which Castagnet is it?'

'Him,' Lesca said. 'I've had that man on my mind every day for twelve years.'

'Twelve,' Coralie said, across the two bowls. 'And it's his wife who gets the chrysanthemums. I've had sixteen and a shopping pad.' She picked the spoon up. 'Well, I asked. What else? Or do I have to hear that at work too?'

'One thing, and it's for the care home. On the night of Friday the 11th the bank breaks at the patch by the last house. That's thirty metres from your back door. Get them out of their beds by 2. Dressed, in the corridor, with the minibus at the glass doors and its tank full. The ones who can walk go first, from the front, because that fills a minibus fastest. Then the walking frames. Then the ones who have to be carried.'

'And who do I say told me?' Coralie said. 'I'm a care assistant, and you cut roadsides.'

'Say nobody. Write it as a list and pin it up. People do what's pinned up.'

Coralie wrote it on the pad, under the soup. Then she stacked the bowls and carried them to the sink. She spoke from there.

'I don't know who I've had at this table. The café says you've got a mayor in you. Whatever I asked, I got an answer. One answer was Jeannot Castagnet, and one was what to do with forty-two people.' She turned on the tap. 'I'd have this one again.'

Under the dish towel Maylis closed her fingers on the cut.

* * *

At 9:05 Coralie turned off the light over the sink and went to the stairs.

Maylis felt her legs lift her out of the chair. Lesca walked her along the passage. Coralie had stopped on the fourth stair with her hand on the rail. She was looking down.

The eyes went up the stairs to Coralie and stayed on her. Maylis knew what Lesca wanted. Maylis had kept still for the village's sake, not for this.

Lesca put the left foot on the first stair.

Maylis grabbed the post at the bottom of the stairs. The dish towel fell off, which left her bare palm on the wood, cut and all. She locked her arm. The post would hold.

Lesca took the body up one stair. Maylis's arm pulled it back down. Lesca pulled again with both legs and with the left hand on the rail. The pull went straight into the cracked rib. Maylis held on.

'What is it?' Coralie said. 'What are you holding on to that for?'

Lesca pulled, and didn't answer her.

Cold came down the stairs from the landing, where the bedroom door stood open. Coralie pulled her arms in against her body and looked up behind her. There was nothing there for her to see. Maylis saw it. Inguma was coming down one stair at a time, with the sound a full sack makes when it is lowered down a step. It kept its back to Coralie as it passed her, and its leaves brushed her ankle.

It came off the last stair and onto Maylis's chest, where she stood. The pulling stopped. Lesca was gone. Inguma had taken her.

Maylis had her legs back, and her mouth, and a left hand on the rail. Her right hand was still locked around the post, though there was nobody left to hold on against.

Coralie hadn't moved from the fourth stair.

'Are you coming up?'

‘I’ll lock up,’ Maylis said.

She got her fingers off the post. She turned the key in the front door, then washed two bowls that were already clean. She had nothing to say on the fourth stair that would have been worth the wait. When she went up an hour later the light was off and Coralie had turned to the wall.

* * *

‘I’ve come about yesterday,’ Maylis said. ‘I want to take it back.’

It was 9 on Tuesday morning, and she was standing in the rain at the window of Larrère’s car.

‘Yesterday,’ Larrère said through the gap. ‘There’s the question of yesterday. It won’t be settled by taking it back. It’ll be settled in writing, and you’re not to worry about the wording, because I have it. Write.’

He passed a sheet of the town hall’s paper out to her, with his pen. She wrote on the roof of his car while he dictated. First came her name and her job. Then came *I resign from the job and give up the key, with effect from.*

‘Stop there. Leave room for a date, and sign under it.’

‘I haven’t resigned.’

He opened a cardboard folder with LESCA M. on the label and held the top sheet against the glass. The sheet was blank.

‘Four winters of nets at your platform, and you hold the key to its lock. I’ve written none of that down. If I do, it goes to the prosecutor at Bayonne with Kévin Labat’s name at the top. That’s prison, for eels.’

She signed with her left hand. Larrère laid the sheet in the folder, on top of the blank one. Eighteen years of work made a thin folder.

‘I keep it. The day you go against me, I put the date in. That gate moves when I say so. And you stay away from the Castagnet house, and from her. What did she tell you?’

‘I asked about her gutter.’

* * *

At 4 that afternoon Sarthou sat her down at the window table of the café and laid a form straight in front of him. He was Jeannot's cousin. Jeannot himself stood at the counter in his rubber boots, with his back to them.

'Complaint of Castagnet, Jean, against persons unknown,' Sarthou said. 'The complainant's duck hut was drained on Monday the 23rd. The gate was raised by its keyholder, on an order. Was the order the mayor's, or the president's?'

Larrère was both.

'Either,' she said.

'Either is not a person. I cannot summon Either to the station.' He wrote, then put his cap on. 'Then this file contains one name, and it is the name of the person who turned the handle.'

He took the form out to his car.

'I didn't want you,' Jeannot said, to his glass. 'I go to the gendarmes for the man who drained my hut, and I come away with little Lesca.'

She went over to the counter. She kept her voice low.

'There are green nets under the floorboards in your hut, folded wet.'

He put the glass down.

'Who's been down through my trapdoor?'

'Nobody. There's a number to ring about nets, on a poster in the town hall entrance. Take the complaint back, and I won't ring it.'

'You've looked the other way for the Labat boy at that gate for four winters, and asked nothing for it,' he said. He put coins down beside the glass. It was still half full. 'That's how Larrère asks for a thing, and you've come in here and done it to me. Friday. You'll have your complaint back.'

He went out.

* * *

When the light began to go she stood on top of the bank and watched Jeannot's van go out along the track to his hut. Then she drove up to the high ground. Larrère's car was turning into the lane behind the Castagnet house with its headlights off. It stopped at the fourth back gate.

In ten days she would be on that platform at night, and all she had of the night was what Lesca chose to tell her. Over there it was written down, in a file in the mayor's office. She wanted to read it for herself. She also wanted one day as the woman who signed things. Over there, Larrère got three minutes and a kitchen timer.

So she would do what Lesca had done to her, and stay sitting.

At 11, on her back in bed, she said the words quietly to the top of the wardrobe. She gave Inguma every metre of roadside she had cut in this village since 2008, to count before it came to take her home. She worked out that the count would take it one working day: eight hours from 6, when Lesca woke up.

Coralie would wake up beside a body with its eyes open and nobody in it. So Maylis wrote *Back at 2* on the shopping pad and stood the pad against the clock radio.

That night, when the warmth beside her in the chair got up to go, she stayed sitting. In the other village Lesca woke up, and Maylis went with her.

* * *

On Wednesday there was frost on the window. Maylis woke up in the mayor's bed, under a dry roof. She was the one driving.

She breathed in. The breath went all the way down and nothing caught. This body had all its ribs. The bed had one pillow.

The right hand was on the blanket in a fist, and a fist was how it stayed. That one was Lesca's.

Maylis walked Lesca's body across the square from the church. The square said good morning. Josiane, who was putting out the café's chairs, said Madame le maire. Nobody asked whether she was still in the box.

She liked it. She slowed down to get more of it.

The stone stood in front of the town hall door, in the space where Larrère parked at home. The top line said JEAN CASTAGNET. She was the line under him, with no word in between.

At home her name wasn't even on her raincoat. Here it was cut in granite. She liked seeing it there. She didn't like what it was under.

Somebody had cleared every drain cover in the square. A mower came around the church. Kévin was driving it, in a yellow raincoat with COMMUNE DE PEYREBARTHE across the back. When he saw the mayor he stopped the mower, took off his cap and waited to hear what he had done wrong.

'You haven't done anything,' Maylis said.

He kept the cap in his hands.

Lesca's right hand waved him on towards the road. He put the cap back on and went.

* * *

At home, in Maylis's bedroom, it was raining. Coralie hadn't gone in to work.

She sat on the edge of the bed in her uniform. Maylis was lying on her back beside her, with her eyes open. Under *Back at 2* on the pad, Coralie had ruled a chart, the kind she kept for a resident. Every half hour she put two fingers on the wrist and wrote down the pulse.

It had been 64 at 6. At 10 it was 58, and it hadn't once gone up.

The pad said 2. She would wait until 2.

* * *

At 10 Maylis stood in the council room with the committee for the twelfth commemoration of the flood, for its minute of silence. A white kitchen timer was set to one.

Maïté stood on the other side of the table in a black coat. On Sunday this same woman had come to her own door in a blue dressing gown, with a potato in her hand. Here she was a widow. Larrère stood next to her and held his hat against his chest.

The minute was for Jean Castagnet. Maylis kept her head down and tried to think of him as dead. That was easy at a funeral. Here all she could find was Jeannot and his letter seventeen, the one that billed the village for two wheel tracks its own tractor had left when it pulled him out.

The laugh started low down. Her own rib would have stopped it. This body had nothing to stop it with.

Lesca's right hand came up and shut over the mouth, so the laugh came out through the mayor's nose.

'You're laughing,' Maïté said. 'In his— In his minute. What is there to laugh at, Madame le maire?'

Lesca's hand came away and left Maylis the mouth. Everything she could have put in it was about Jeannot, who was alive.

'I'll lay the flowers on the 12th, because they're his,' Maïté said. 'After I lay them, you— Don't kiss me, up there. Not this year.'

She went out. Then the timer rang.

Larrère put his hat on and went out after her.

* * *

That left Maylis alone in the town hall until 2. She took the flood file for 2014 down from the cupboard, sat down at the mayor's desk and turned to the last page. The gendarmes had typed the night in three lines.

02:45. Water through the bank at the repair beside the last house, across the width of a door. The keyholder gave the bank ten minutes.

02:55. Gate raised by the keyholder, by hand. No order had been given to raise it.

First light. CASTAGNET Jean recovered from the cellar of his duck hut. Trapdoor locked on the inside. Watch stopped at 03:11.

She read it the way she read a job sheet, for what the job would need. The repair was her patch. And Castagnet had locked himself in, so somebody would have to walk down that track and knock. Not one of the three lines said whether anybody had.

When she went to shut the folder, the left hand was slow. She had to tell it twice.

At home she had left a body on its back with nobody in it.

At 2 the secretary opened the town hall. She turned over the day's letters on the mayor's desk, and Lesca's right hand signed each of them without waiting to be asked.

The church clock struck 2, the hour on Maylis's pad. Maylis sat still and waited for the cold.

Outside, something dry was being dragged across the ground. She took hold of the edge of the desk with the left hand and shut the eyes.

The right hand went on signing.

'That's Kévin, Madame le maire,' the secretary said. 'With the leaves.'

He was crossing the square in front of the stone, pulling a plastic sheet by one corner. It was piled with plane leaves. Maylis would have taken the trailer.

Nothing came at 2:05. Nothing came at 2:30.

'Give me ten minutes,' Maylis told the secretary.

When the door had shut Maylis got down on the mayor's floor, on her back, beside the filing cupboard, with

her arms by her sides. She said the words to the ceiling. Then she told Inguma to leave the roadsides and come for her now.

It didn't come. Next to her, Lesca's right hand tapped its fingers on the floorboards.

Maylis had worked out the count at the speed of the village tractor. Inguma was doing the roadsides on foot. Nobody had taught her any words for calling it back.

The door opened. The secretary bent down and put the next letter on the floor beside Lesca's hand, and the hand signed it.

'Council is at 6:30,' she said.

If Inguma never came, all of this was hers: the desk, the stone, a square that said good morning. That morning, standing in front of the stone, she might have said yes to it. But all of it came with Kévin's cap and one pillow.

* * *

By 3 Coralie was an hour past what the pad said.

She wrote 47 under 48. At work she always rang the doctor for any pulse under 40, without asking anybody first. She brought his number up on her phone.

She didn't ring it. A doctor would put Maylis in an ambulance to Bayonne, and this was the bed Maylis had to come back to.

* * *

Thirteen people stood behind their chairs in the council room and waited for the mayor to sit. Maylis had never kept anybody waiting in her life, so she took her time over it.

The white kitchen timer stood on the table by Lesca's right hand.

Maylis pointed at it. 'I want that.'

'The timer?' the secretary said. 'You have it, Madame le maire. It's in the inventory.'

'An item from the chair,' Maylis said. 'The night of the flood. What order did the keyholder have?'

'You were the keyholder, Madame le maire,' the secretary said.

'For the minutes,' Maylis said.

'On that item,' Larrère said, and stood up.

Every head turned to the timer. Lesca's right hand already had the dial between finger and thumb. Maylis pinned its wrist to the table with the left.

'A president gives his order by phone, at the hour it's needed,' he said. 'And no president will ever put a river on three hundred hectares for a flood that hasn't come.'

At three minutes he stopped for the bell. No bell came. He looked at the timer, then at the one hand lying on top of the other. Then he went on, like a man who has found a door unlocked.

'Eleven years I've been timed like an egg,' he said. 'I have sentences in that register with no ends on them. The secretary will find one under the item on the gate cameras. "A man can no longer—" The timer rang there. It ends: stand at his own gate without the prefecture watching. I'm told I wave at the camera.'

The council put its pens down to watch.

'The Labat boy got a sentence out of those cameras too,' Larrère said, 'and his had an end on it. Six months in prison, for a few kilos of eels. The mayor sent the film to the gendarmes herself. His mother was the mayor's deputy, and she handed her own sash back across this table in a plastic bag. When he came out, the mayor gave him a mower and the village's coat.'

Marie-Jo kept her eyes on the wall. Maylis looked at the hand she was holding down.

* * *

At home, in Maylis's bedroom, the clock radio said 18:40.

The last line on the chart said 36. Coralie sat on the edge of the bed with her phone in her hand. The doctor's number was on the screen, with her thumb over it.

She had been in room twelve when Madame Etcheto told them what happens to the one Inguma can't take home. She had made a joke of it then.

* * *

'And this morning she laughs in the minute, in front of his widow,' Larrère said. 'I walked Madame Castagnet to her gate myself. Since nobody's ringing that bell, I'll say what Josiane says at her counter. Twelve winters the mayor has been up at that house with a ladder, and no vote sent her. A woman keeps going to a house because she's after the husband or because she's after the wife. In that house the husband is on the stone.'

The deputy mayor looked at the water jug.

Maylis had crossed from one village to the other, and Josiane had still got there first.

‘I go in at the front, Guy,’ Maylis said. ‘In daylight, and she holds the ladder. I’ve never had to leave my car in the back lane with its lights off.’

He stopped with his mouth open on the next word.

She hadn’t known whether he had a back lane here. He had.

‘Whose car, Madame le maire?’ The secretary had her pen up. ‘For the minutes.’

‘Monsieur Larrère has the floor,’ Maylis said.

He had the floor, and he didn’t want it any more. He started on the corn and lost his place in it. He looked at the timer for help. By then he had been on his feet for twenty minutes.

‘My order that night was to keep the gate shut. If that gate had stayed shut, Jean Castagnet would have stayed dry, and he would have walked up that track in the morning. Madame Castagnet still leaves her kitchen light on, every night of the season. So I move that on the 12th the prefect speak alone. The mayor is the only one who was on the platform, and I have never asked her. When you stood on that platform, did you—’

Lesca’s wrist went out from under the left hand. The right hand took the dial, turned it all the way around and back to nothing, and the bell rang.

‘That’s the member’s time,’ Marie-Jo said, to the wall above Maylis’s head. ‘It goes to the vote.’

Maylis didn’t know how his question ended. Lesca’s hand knew. It had the timer face down on the table and was leaning on it.

‘Those in favour,’ Maylis said.

Seven hands went up. Larrère’s was the highest.

‘Against.’

Six went up. Then Maylis put up the left hand, and Lesca’s right hand let go of the timer and went up beside it.

‘The chair votes once, Madame le maire,’ the secretary said. ‘Seven and seven. In a tie the chair’s vote decides. The motion fails. The mayor speaks after the prefect.’

Larrère shut his book and spoke to the table.

‘She’s voted herself onto the stage. A metre from that stone, with a camera on her. I’ll have my answer there.’

The church clock began to strike 7.

Out in the corridor something dry was dragged along the floor. This time it wasn't a plastic sheet.

It was five hours late.

Inguma came along under the table, past a row of shoes, and climbed onto her chest where she sat. Its leaves pressed against the register. She couldn't lift a finger of either hand, and the council of Peyrebarthe watched its mayor not lift one.

Something wet touched Maylis's left eye and she blinked. It was the first time she had blinked since 6 that morning.

She was back in her own bed, with rain falling on the roof. Coralie sat on the edge of the bed in her uniform, with a square of wet cotton in one hand and her phone at her ear. Maylis could hear it ringing at the doctor's end.

Coralie saw the blink. She ended the call, laid the phone face down on the blanket and took the wrist.

'Your pulse was 34 when I rang him,' she said, when she had counted. 'Now it's 44.'

Maylis wanted to close her hand over those two fingers. The hand was cold and it stayed open.

Coralie had put her own pillow under Maylis's knees. The pad was on the blanket. The pulse went down the chart from 64 to 34, beside two columns of ticks headed *eyes* and *turned*.

'Your pad said 2,' she said. 'It's 7. Thirteen hours, with your eyes open, and I haven't gone in to work. Where have you been, Maylis?'

'At work.'

Coralie stood up.

'That's where I was meant to be,' she said. She pulled her pillow out from under Maylis's knees. 'I'm taking the spare room, because I can't lie next to that and sleep. Ask me back across the landing and I'll come. But you'll have to ask.'

Coralie waited in the doorway with the pillow under her arm. When nothing came, she gave her the rest in the voice she used at work.

'And tomorrow you'll want to make up the day. No sacks. You don't lift with that rib, and you don't push against anything. A cracked rib mends if it's left alone. Push on it and it goes through into the lung. I've seen one do it. The man was eighty-one. He pushed himself up the bed on the rail to reach his glasses. When I got to him his lips were blue. He said his mouth tasted of coins. He coughed, and it came out pink on the sheet. His breath stopped halfway down, and then at his collar. He was dead before the doctor had his coat off.'

She crossed the landing. She left both doors open, and Maylis heard the pillow go down on the single bed in the spare room.

* * *

That night Maylis set out to keep herself out of the chair.

She got into bed on her left side, at the edge, with her knees up, so that Inguma would have nowhere to sit. The rib let her have an hour of it and then put her on her back.

At 2:51 Inguma came down off the wardrobe and sat on her chest. Maylis pushed. Every breath went through the crack in the rib. Inguma pressed down just as hard. The first night it had got down after three minutes. This time it stayed. Maylis pushed until the church clock struck 4, when Inguma got down and left the way it had come. Afterwards she took a breath all the way down and ran her tongue around her mouth. Nothing.

On Thursday night she took a blanket down to the kitchen and got down on the floor between the table and the stove. At 2:51 Inguma came down the stairs, with the sound of a sack being lowered down a step, and it found her. She pushed until 4 again.

When it had gone she stayed on the floor and took a breath. The breath stopped halfway down. Her mouth tasted of coins. She pulled herself up by the leg of the table, coughed into the sink and looked. It was pink.

She ran the tap until the sink was white again. She was back in her own bed before Coralie's alarm rang.

* * *

At 10 on Friday 4 December Maylis was crossing the square when Bordenave knocked on the café window. She went in. He had the pad open at the page headed *Madame le maire*.

'Friday the 4th, in the morning,' he read out. 'Seventy under the line.' He looked at her over his glasses. 'I walked down at 9. It's a metre, and the road's dry.'

'Put a cross by it,' the dealer said. 'That's her first.'

Bordenave drew the cross. Jeannot turned around on his stool to watch him do it.

'Your mayor's thirty centimetres wrong,' Jeannot said. 'If she can be wrong about Friday the 4th, she can be wrong about Friday the 11th.' He lifted his glass to Maylis. 'That's the best thing on that pad.'

Maylis had kept out of the chair for two nights. She meant to have a third before she asked Coralie back.

That night she got into her own bed, on her back. Her breath had stopped halfway down all day. Inguma came down at its minute. Maylis took what breath there was and held it. Then she let it go and kept still.

The arms of the chair were warm.

When Maylis got up out of the chair at 6, Lesca stayed sitting in it. It was Lesca who got her out of bed. By 6:20 Lesca had sent Inguma off to count the lake again.

* * *

By noon on Saturday it was raining.

That afternoon Lesca walked her down through the Port to the bank. The cellar door at the side of Bordenave's house was open, and a row of jam jars stood in the rain beside it. He was at the bottom of the steps in his rubber boots, in water over his ankles.

'This floor was dry yesterday,' he said, and held another jar up to her. 'The cross stays. Friday was a metre.'

Maylis took the jar in her right hand and stood it with the others.

On the platform Lesca read the pillar.

'Fifty-five under,' Lesca said out loud, to the right hand. 'My file has the same.'

On Wednesday and Thursday nights Maylis had pushed Inguma off until 4 and never reached the chair. Thursday and Friday were the only dry days since the 24th. Last night Maylis had kept still. Lesca had got her out of bed at 6, and by noon it was raining again.

It was only two days. Bordenave would have called that weather. Maylis didn't, but she had nobody to say it to.

Lesca had taken the watch off Maylis's right wrist and was holding it in the left hand, out of the rain.

'From this handle to his trapdoor,' Lesca said. 'On foot, in this mud.'

Lesca waited for the watch to reach the full minute, then walked her down off the bank and onto the track.

The track ran straight out across the flood fields for a kilometre. Wheels had cut two lines along it and both were full of water, so Lesca kept to the grass between them. Every few steps the rib caught. Lesca didn't slow down for it.

A little past halfway came the dip, where the track went down into a hollow that was under water from one side to the other. The legs went through it with the water over the ankles of the boots.

The track ended in a circle of bare mud, where Jeannot turned his van around every night. Beyond the mud was the duck hut. From outside it was only a low bump in the tall grass, with a chimney pipe sticking up out of it and a wooden trapdoor on top. There was no van and no smoke.

The legs took her up onto the hut and stopped on the trapdoor. The wood sounded hollow under the boots.

‘Twenty-five minutes,’ Lesca said.

Twenty-five minutes was a trailer of leaves to the dump and back.

The legs didn’t step off. Maylis felt the eyes go down between the boots to the boards and stay there, while the rain ran off the hood onto them.

‘When that bank starts to go, it has ten minutes,’ Lesca said. ‘I had my hand on it.’

Maylis held out her right hand for the watch and Lesca gave it to her. Maylis looked back the way they had come. The bank was a dark line across the end of the fields, with the roofs of the Port at one end of it. The gate was a post on top of that line, no bigger than a nail.

Maylis stood on Jeannot’s trapdoor in the rain. It had been dry out here on Thursday, and on Friday. She couldn’t step off the trapdoor until Lesca did.

8

Lesca was walking Maylis back along the track when Jeannot's van came down off the bank towards them. Lesca stepped into the wet grass to let it by. He drove past at walking pace. He looked at the mud on her boots and at the watch in her hand. Then he looked down his track to where it ended, and drove on.

* * *

That evening was bingo night in the village hall.

'Thirty-four. Three, four.'

Maylis stood behind the bar, beside the big coffee pot, while Lesca did the serving with the left hand. From there she could see three rows of tables on the waxed floor, under strip lights. They had paper tablecloths, and at each place there was a card and a small dish of corn to mark it with. Marie-Jo was calling from the stage, each number whole and then in parts. Coralie had brought the residents up in the minibus and sat them at the table by the radiators.

Every head in the hall went down over a card. By the radiators the two Lassalle sisters shared one card and held hands under the tablecloth. The woman next to them marked hers, with her tongue between her teeth.

Maylis had her own teeth shut. Inguma would come for Lesca tonight. All Maylis had to do was keep the mouth shut until it came, so that Lesca couldn't give it anything else to count.

Josiane came up to the bar between two numbers and put a coin down.

'A coffee. Is that pot hot this year, or do I wait?'

Lesca pulled at the jaw and Maylis held it, so all Josiane got was a noise through the nose.

'Is that a yes?'

'Seventy-one. Seven, one.'

'Here,' Monsieur Daguerre said, from his wheelchair.

'Not yet, Monsieur Daguerre,' Coralie said. 'You want seventeen for the line. That was seventy-one.'

The left hand was holding a cup under the tap of the coffee pot. Lesca was still pulling at the jaw and wasn't

watching the cup. The coffee came up to the top and went over. It ran along the bar and off the end, onto Josiane's shoes.

'That's full,' Josiane said, and stepped back. 'Maylis. It's full.'

Maylis reached across with her right hand and shut the tap.

'Have you got toothache, Maylis?' Marie-Jo said into the microphone. The whole hall looked up from its cards at the bar. 'See the dentist on Monday. Fifty. Five, zero.'

'I am reporting a line,' Sarthou said, two tables down. He put his cap on to go up for his prize, a grass trimmer. It was better than the one in Maylis's shed.

'That's no tooth,' Josiane said. She had carried her cup back to the end of the second row, where Jeannot sat with two cards. She said it over his head, to the row behind. 'She's got her mouth shut because he's in the room. She doesn't dare open it, in case of what comes out.'

Jeannot left his two cards and came up to the bar for a glass.

'You've had your complaint back,' he said. 'What's left on me to look at?'

The teeth came apart.

'You're breathing,' Lesca said. Maylis got them shut again behind it.

He carried his glass back to his cards.

'Two words,' Josiane told the second row. 'I got none for a coffee, and he gets two.'

'I can wait,' Marie-Jo said into the microphone. 'The duck can't. It was fresh on Thursday.'

The duck was on the edge of the stage in white paper, with its feet sticking out. The hall went quiet and played for it.

'Twelve. One, two.'

Madame Etcheto put a grain of corn on her card. She didn't call out. She lifted one hand off the tablecloth, and Coralie called it for her.

'Line. By the radiators.'

'Twelve. That's my door,' Madame Etcheto said.

Bixente carried the duck down the hall to her. She took it on her knees and kept both hands on it.

The ham came after the duck. By then the bar was wet from one end to the other.

‘Sixty-eight. Six, eight.’

‘Line,’ Jeannot said.

He went up for it. On his way back he stopped at the bar, with the ham under his arm, and turned to face the tables.

‘I’ll say this to all of you while you’re sitting down. On the Monday she forbids me to go to my hut on the 11th. This afternoon she’s down my track at my trapdoor with a watch in her hand. On Friday the 11th I’ll be in my hut.’

The hall clapped.

‘Jean,’ Lesca said. ‘Don’t.’

Maylis had let go of the teeth for that. She would have said it herself.

‘It’s Jeannot,’ he said.

‘Full card now, for the big basket,’ Marie-Jo said. ‘Forty-four. Four, four.’

By the radiators Madame Etcheto lifted her head and watched the door.

Inguma had come in. Maylis saw the paper tablecloths lift along the first row, one table after another, as it came up the hall under them towards the bar. The Lassalle sisters put their free hands flat on their card.

‘Who’s left that door open?’ Josiane said.

Lesca raised the voice. ‘Inguma, enauk—’

Maylis shut the teeth on the rest.

‘Twenty-nine. Two, nine.’

Nobody marked it. The hall was watching Maylis. Lesca pulled hard at the jaw, and it went from side to side.

‘Tooth,’ Marie-Jo said into the microphone.

The teeth came apart. Maylis got to the mouth first. She had breath for three words. They were for Lesca, and the whole hall heard them.

‘You’re the water.’

Jeannot was still standing in front of her with the ham under his arm.

‘She wants water,’ one of the Lassalle sisters said.

‘She’s got a bar full of coffee,’ said her sister.

‘It’s him she wants,’ Josiane told the second row. ‘You can go three weeks without bread. Without water it’s three days. She’s just told him which he is.’

‘How do I put that?’ Bordenave said. He had the café’s pad open at her page. ‘It’s got no date.’

Maylis felt the pull go out of the jaw. The left hand had been pushing a cloth along the wet bar. It stopped.

The cold reached the bar and came over it.

‘That wasn’t for Castagnet,’ Madame Etcheto said to Coralie, and sat up over her duck. She was watching Maylis the way she would have watched a child stuck in the middle of a prayer. She said the rest for her, slowly, across the hall.

‘Hire beldur. You’ll count the corn in this hall. On the cards, and in the dishes, and what’s left in the sack. You’re not to come till you’ve finished.’

The tablecloths came down again, one after another, all the way back to the door.

The sack held twenty kilos.

‘That’s till morning,’ Madame Etcheto told Coralie, and settled her hands on the duck.

‘How’s that spelled?’ Bordenave said.

* * *

In Lesca’s own bedroom the clock radio said 23:55. Her mother had sat beside the bed since noon with her coat on. Coralie was asleep across the landing with her door open.

‘Your father slept with his mouth open,’ Arlette said. ‘I could hear him from the yard. You never made a sound, even as a baby. I used to get up to see.’

From her chair by the bed she couldn’t hear the breath any more, so she got up. She had to bend down until her ear was over the mouth. She stayed there.

* * *

At midnight, in Maylis’s house, Lesca walked her up the stairs, to the open door of the spare room. Coralie was

sitting on the single bed in her uniform, taking off her watch.

‘You said to ask, and you’d come back across,’ Lesca said. By now Lesca had the voice nearly right, higher, the way Maylis used it. ‘I’m asking.’

Maylis had used herself up at the bar. She couldn’t get one word out to say who was really asking.

Coralie laid the watch on the chair beside the bed. She didn’t get up.

‘Which of you is that?’

‘The one who’s asking.’

Coralie picked up her pillow and came out onto the landing with it under her arm. It was four steps from that door to the other. She took two of them. Then she stopped, took hold of the right wrist and put two fingers on the inside of it.

Maylis pulled. The wrist was all she had left to pull with.

Coralie kept her fingers where they were and counted.

‘That’s her,’ she said. ‘In this hand. I’ve had sixteen years of her saying nothing, and I know it when I’ve got hold of it.’ She looked up at the face. ‘And you’re the one I had soup with. You nearly had me across. So I’ll tell you something, since you’d give me an answer. I want the geriatric floor at the hospital in Bayonne, on nights. I held my first hand on that floor, at twenty, under a night nurse called Ithurbide. She ran thirty beds with a torch and a list, and I wanted to be her before I’d heard of Peyrebarthe. I’ve had the form since March. I posted it today, and I posted it for me.’

‘Then take it. I’ll drive you in.’

Coralie took the third step with the wrist still in her fingers. That brought her close enough, and Lesca put the left hand on the pillow.

Coralie looked down at the hand she was holding. She stood like that, one step from her own bedroom door, with a pulse under her fingers and the left hand on her pillow.

‘I’d have the one who answers,’ she said. ‘Ask me tomorrow and I’d have you. But it’s the other one’s bed, and she’s in this wrist hearing every word, and she hasn’t asked me into it. I don’t get into a bed over somebody who can’t speak. I’ve lifted too many of them.’ She let go of the wrist and took the pillow out from under the left hand. ‘You’ll go back down those stairs.’

She went back to the door of the spare room and stopped in it.

‘One more, since you answer. Over the soup you told me you’d had Jeannot Castagnet on your mind every day for twelve years. What is he to you?’

The mouth stayed shut. Maylis wasn’t the one holding it.

Coralie waited. Then she went in and shut the door.

Lesca kept Maylis standing on the landing in front of that door. The light under it went out. Maylis heard the pillow go down on the single bed.

On Sunday 6 December it was raining. Lesca was sitting in Maylis's chair at the kitchen table, with the left hand around a bowl of coffee, when Coralie came down in her dressing gown. She sat down across the bread from her.

'It's still you,' Coralie said. 'On Monday it fetched you off my stairs. I felt the cold go past me.'

'It did. This time I've come to stay.'

Coralie pulled the shopping pad across the table. Wednesday's page was on top, with the pulse going down to 34.

'That was thirteen hours,' she said. 'What's lying in your bed, wherever that is? And for how long now?'

'My own body, with its eyes open. Since 6 yesterday.' Lesca had to tell the left hand twice before it lifted the bowl. 'It's colder each time I go back to it.'

Coralie turned to a clean page. She ruled two lines down it and wrote a heading over each of the three columns. *What. Since when. How do you know.*

'Maylis got three words out at that bar,' she said. "'You're the water.'" The hall thought she was thirsty. Madame Etcheto was sitting next to me, and she said it wasn't for Castagnet.' She turned the pad around and laid the pencil across it. 'That wasn't your voice. So I'm asking the one who said it.'

Maylis felt the jaw come loose. Lesca had let go of it.

'She's the flood,' Maylis said. 'She's the mayor of another Peyrebarthe, where the river came through the bank on 11 December 2014. Jeannot drowned in his hut that night, and that's what he is to her. When she comes over into me she brings her river with her.'

Coralie took the pad back and wrote. 'Since when?'

'Since the night of Monday the 23rd. That was my first night on my back, and it started raining.'

'How do you know?'

'I kept her out for two nights, and the road dried,' Maylis said. 'Bordenave has it on his pad, with a cross. On

Friday night she got back in. By noon yesterday it was raining, and before dark the river was where she'd said it would be.'

Coralie didn't look up. She went down the dates with the point of the pencil, one at a time.

'And what puts her out?'

'The thing that sits on me. You felt it go past you on the stairs. I've been fighting it since the rib, and half the time it was doing my job.'

'Madame Etcheto's Inguma,' Coralie said. The pencil stopped. 'Last night she sent it off to count corn. I sat beside her and watched her do it.'

She turned the pad around again, towards the left hand. Then she looked at the face.

'I said I'd have you tomorrow,' she said. 'It's tomorrow, and I've got one question. Is that chart right?'

Maylis let Lesca have the mouth.

'It's the tide,' Lesca said, in the low voice. 'It has rained for the best part of two weeks, and there are big tides this week. Rivers come up in December. She has a cracked rib and she doesn't sleep.'

Coralie put her finger on the third column.

'A tide comes in twice a day. It doesn't take Thursday off.' She kept the finger where it was. 'You sat at this table and told me to have them all out of their beds by 2 on that Friday, with the ones who can walk first. I wrote it down and pinned it up at work. You knew which wall it comes through. Now she tells me who's bringing it, and you give me the tide.' She took the pad back. 'I'd have had you. You answer. But what I'd have had is a river over forty-two beds.'

Outside the kitchen door something heavy was set down on the step, like a sack.

Lesca took a breath for the words that would send it off to count. Coralie saw her do it. She reached across the bread and put her hand flat over the mouth.

Lesca got one word out around Coralie's fingers.

'Friday.'

The door didn't open. Inguma was on the chest all the same, at the kitchen table, with its leaves against the bread. Lesca was gone.

Coralie took her hand away. Maylis had the whole of herself back, but her right hand was slow coming up to

wipe her mouth. Coralie held two fingers out across the bread. 'Squeeze.'

Maylis squeezed. A grip like that wouldn't hold a rake. 'That's as hard as I can,' she said.

'On Monday that hand held the stair post against the rest of you.'

'She was in for a day and a night. If she gets in again on Friday night, I may not get even the hand back.'

Coralie tore the chart off the pad, folded it in four and put it in the pocket of her dressing gown.

'That's one thing you've told me,' she said. 'Now another. I told her about Bayonne last night. You were there, and you heard it. What do you say to that, Maylis?'

Maylis wanted to tell her not to go. But Coralie had wanted that floor since she was twenty. She had waited since March to tell anybody.

'It's twenty minutes to Bayonne,' Maylis said.

Coralie picked up the bowl of coffee and poured it down the sink.

* * *

That night Maylis didn't push. Then she was in the chair. Lesca was already out of it, standing under the two lamps with her hands behind her back.

'It's the ti—' Lesca said. She started again, and it stuck on the same word.

'It came out in my kitchen,' Maylis said.

'This isn't your kitchen.' Lesca's fist closed. 'A week ago you asked me why it comes, and I told you I didn't know.'

Maylis waited for her to say so again. She didn't.

The door of the box opened and Inguma came in over the step. Maylis moved out of its way.

* * *

On Tuesday Coralie stopped at the bedroom door in her uniform, with her keys in her hand.

'They want two of us on at night, with the river this high,' she said. 'I've asked to be one of them. I'm on nights from Friday.'

At 3 that afternoon Maylis was up on the bank. The river had come up to her father's line. She walked along to

the patch. It was darker than the clay around it, and it shone. A line of water no wider than a shoelace had come out at the bottom. It ran across the road and stopped against Sarthou's doorstep. Mending the patch was a job for a dry week.

She was crossing the square when Larrère stopped his car outside the café and lowered his window a few centimetres. The café door was open.

'They tell me the river's at the line,' he said. 'The prefecture at Pau has sent a yellow warning. The gate stays shut. People in the Port know they live by a river.'

Inside the café Bordenave turned the score pad to the page headed *Madame le maire*. He read the first entry out loud, towards the open door.

'Monday 30 November. She says the mayor will tell her on Tuesday the 8th, at this door, that the river's at the line, that the gate stays shut, and that people in the Port know they live by a river.' He looked at the car over his glasses. 'I wrote that eight days ago, Guy.'

The window was still open. Nothing came through it.

Bordenave tore off a clean page and wrote across the top. *The Port asks for the gate to be raised on Friday the 11th, in daylight, on the falling tide*. He signed it.

'Give it here,' Madame Darrigrand said. She held the page against the door frame and signed it with her baby on her arm. 'I'm two doors up from Sarthou, and his step's wet.' She looked at Maylis over the baby's head. 'You've got the key. I'm signing for you to use it.'

The page came back with nine names on it. Bordenave carried it out into the rain and pushed it through the gap in the window.

'The association will be consulted,' Larrère said. 'At 4. Here will do.'

* * *

'I'm heating the whole square,' Josiane said from behind the counter.

'We can't shut the door,' the oldest member said. 'The president's on the other side of it.'

The landowners' association sat at the card table, six members in their coats. Larrère chaired them from the driver's seat of his car. He had parked it at the open door with the engine running.

Maylis stood at the counter. Jeannot stayed on his stool. He held the seventh vote, for the hunters.

Out in the square a string of the Christmas lights had gone dark. Kévin was up a ladder mending it, in the rain.

‘The petition,’ Larrère said through the window. ‘The Port asks. Does the keyholder ask too? Open, or shut?’

‘Open,’ Maylis said. ‘On Friday at 2, on the falling tide, with nobody on the fields, by your order.’

He took the blank sheet out of his folder and wrote two words at the top. Then he held the sheet against the glass until she had read them.

Labat, Kévin.

Behind the car Kévin was still on his ladder. Maylis didn’t say it again.

‘Those in favour of the petition.’

Three hands went up at the card table. The other three stayed down.

‘Three against three,’ Larrère said. ‘Then the hunters have the last vote. Castagnet. Those against.’

Jeannot turned around on his stool with his glass. He kept his back to the car and his eyes on Maylis.

‘Today she wants my hut filled to the trapdoor on a Friday afternoon, and she wants my hand up for it. Her mayor got Friday the 4th wrong. That’s on the pad, with a cross by it. So I go by the pillar, and the pillar says that river’s behind its bank.’ He put his hand up where the car could see it. ‘Nobody tells me what’s under my floorboards and then tells me how to vote. Shut.’

‘Four to three,’ Larrère said. ‘It stays shut.’

His car pulled away. Josiane came around the counter and shut the door.

Jeannot kept his hand up until the car had left the square.

* * *

‘From his car?’ Coralie said that evening, at the stove. ‘I had it at work by 5, and I didn’t believe it.’

‘With the engine running. Three against three, and him through the window.’

Coralie put the spoon down, opened the oven door a few centimetres and bent to the gap.

‘The soup will be consulted,’ she said, in the voice from the back of the throat. ‘Those in favour.’ She counted along the oven shelf. ‘Three against three. It stays shut,’ she said, and shut the door on him.

Maylis laughed. The laugh still caught at the rib, so she pressed her forearm to her side and went on laughing.

Coralie watched her until it was over. Then she turned back to the stove.

When Coralie had gone up, Maylis turned the shopping pad over on the kitchen table and wrote Friday night out on the back, as a job.

Friday 11th, night. The gate.

Key. Same key for the handle box.

Eighteen turns lift the gate off the stone. It sticks at nineteen. Left shoulder under the handle.

Larrère will ring. Let it ring.

White van at the end of the track. He'll be in his hut.

The trapdoor. Walk down and knock.

Coralie is at the care home that night. Thirty metres from the patch.

Coralie came down in her dressing gown for a glass of water. She saw the writing on the back of the pad and read it, standing under the lamp. When she came to the line with her own name in it, she put a finger under it.

‘There’s a key, and a handle, and Larrère, and a van. And then there’s me, as a distance.’

‘It’s so I know where you are,’ Maylis said.

‘I know where I am. I’m asking where I am in this.’

Coralie turned the pad over to the front, where the week’s boxes were. All of them were empty. Under them she wrote *Friday 11th, night* and drew one box beside it. She left the pencil lying across the pad.

* * *

That night Maylis tried the words the way Madame Etcheto used them, to keep Inguma off.

She stayed awake, on her back in bed. At 2:51 it came down off the wardrobe and hit the floor.

‘Inguma, enauk hire beldur,’ she said.

It stopped where it had landed and waited for its work.

She had two jobs she could give it. There were her roadsides, every metre she had cut since 2008. And there was the corn in the village hall, which Madame Etcheto had given it on bingo night. Each would keep it busy till morning.

The clock radio went to 02:52. Inguma was still waiting.

‘Either,’ Maylis said.

It crossed the room, jumped onto the bed and sat down on her chest.

Then she was in the chair, with Lesca beside her. Maylis stood up out of it and spoke first.

‘I said the words to it.’

‘What did you give it to count?’

Maylis didn’t answer. Lesca didn’t ask twice.

‘I kept you out for two nights,’ Maylis said. ‘A third puts this rib through my lung. So I’m asking. Don’t come on Friday.’

Lesca’s fist closed. ‘I’m not going to say I won’t.’

‘You know what you bring with you. What are you coming for?’

‘I left a man at the end of that track. This time I’m coming to get him out.’ Lesca’s fist opened. ‘To stay,’ she said. ‘Over there I’ve got a woman across a landing, and a stone with my name cut into it. I’ve had one bowl of soup at your table.’

‘Then I’ve worked out what that costs me. It’s a whole life with one hand. I won’t pay that. Friday is the night the river comes through. That’s the one night I have to keep you out for. I can’t push, and I can’t give it its work. So on Friday I won’t lie down. I’ll sit up in the van, awake, until 4, when it gives up.’

‘And if you nod off at 2, you’re where I was. It’s the middle of the night, there’s water coming through your bank, and he’s out there in his hut.’

‘Then I want both,’ Maylis said. ‘The gate up, and him out of that cellar first.’

‘There’s no both. You walked it with me. You turn the handle first.’

‘Both,’ Maylis said.

Behind Lesca, one wall of the steel room was gone. Where it had been, a waxed wooden floor ran out from the steel under strip lights. There were three rows of tables on it, with paper tablecloths. A voice was calling numbers, each one whole and then in parts. At each place somebody sat with their head down over a card. They were the dead of Peyrebarthe. Maylis had dug the graves for many of them.

One chair was empty.

‘That’s where I sit if I stay with you,’ Lesca said. She hadn’t turned around to look. ‘The old woman in room twelve told you. I’ve worked out what I’d be giving up, and I’ve written it down. Nil.’

The door of the box opened. Inguma came in over the step, climbed into the chair and waited. It filled the seat from arm to arm.

‘On Friday night I’m coming across with you, and I won’t be sent home,’ Lesca said. ‘Your pad says Coralie is at the care home that night, so the only one left to stop me is you, with one hand.’

Maylis turned her back on her and walked out onto the wooden floor, towards the empty chair. Her father was sitting at the end of the second row with his watch beside his card. She stopped and laid her right hand on the tablecloth next to the watch, palm up. He marked a number. He didn’t look up, and she took the hand away.

The chair next to the empty one was taken. Jean Castagnet sat there in two jackets, with his head down and a card in each hand.

At the empty place there was a small dish of corn and a card. A name was printed across the top of the card, surname first.

LESCA, MAYLIS.

On Thursday 10 December Coralie had the late shift. At 10 that night she was standing outside room twelve, at the bank end of the care home, with water over the toes of her shoes.

It had come in under the back door after lights-out. Now it was all along the corridor, brown, from the door past twelve and eleven. Bixente pushed it back with his mop. It came in again behind him.

‘It’s the drain in the yard,’ he said.

The care home had no sandbags. It had towels. Coralie had rolled all the bath towels in the cupboard and packed them along the bottom of the door. On top were the pads that went under a resident at night. A pad was made to hold a litre. Coralie had never seen one fail. Each of these had taken its litre and was now as fat as a pillow. Bixente’s yellow sign stood in the middle of it all. *Caution. Wet floor.*

Door twelve stood a little open.

‘That’s river,’ Madame Etcheto said. ‘I can smell it from my bed. And that boy’s mopping it the wrong way. Water goes out by the door it came in at. Open it.’

‘There’s more of it outside, Madame Etcheto.’

Coralie went in. Madame Etcheto was lying against her two pillows, facing her wardrobe. Her slippers stood side by side under the bed, in the water.

‘I’d like you at the front tonight,’ Coralie said. ‘There’s a bed made up in three, and it’s dry.’

Madame Etcheto looked past her at the number on the open door.

‘That’s my door.’

Coralie picked the slippers up and stood them on the radiator.

* * *

‘Hand,’ Coralie said when she got in from the late shift.

Maylis already had it on the kitchen table, palm up under the lamp, next to the scissors and the clean roll. They had done this every evening for ten days. Coralie unwrapped the old bandage and turned the palm to the light.

‘That’s closing up. You’ll have a scar there.’ She laid two fingers across the palm and Maylis squeezed them, no harder than on Sunday. Coralie took the end of the new roll in her teeth. She said something around it.

‘Under the thumb,’ Maylis said. She put a finger on the first turn to hold it.

Coralie wrapped the hand. She said something longer around the bandage, with a question at the end.

‘Duck,’ Maylis said.

Coralie stopped wrapping and took the bandage out of her mouth.

‘I’ll have to ask you everything like that.’

Maylis laughed. Coralie’s free hand was flat on Maylis’s right side before the laugh got there. It held the rib while she laughed.

‘The yard came in under our back door tonight,’ Coralie said. She hadn’t taken the hand away. ‘I’m the second one on tomorrow night, with Nadine. We have to have the minibus fuelled and the wheelchairs by the door.’ She tucked in the end of the bandage. ‘Where will you be?’

‘The van will be at the gate from dusk.’

The hand came off her side.

‘I asked where you’d be,’ Coralie said. She went up to the spare room.

* * *

That night Maylis kept still under Inguma, and then she was in the chair. The arms of the chair were cold. Lesca wasn’t in it yet, but the night of the flood came to Maylis anyway, the one Lesca had gone over every night for twelve years.

A phone rang in the dark beside Lesca’s bed. The wall side of the bed was empty, because Coralie was working nights that week. Lesca picked up the phone without turning on the light. The screen showed a landline number with no name. It was Larrère. He said the river was ninety centimetres over the red line and rising. The floodgate was to stay shut. She was to go down and stand by it and do nothing until he rang again. Behind his voice a clock was ticking close to the phone, the kind that hangs in a kitchen.

When she drove past the care home, Coralie’s car was in the yard. At the end of the road water was coming through the bank. Before she fitted the handle to the gate, she turned the van around on top of the bank so that its headlights pointed down the track across the flood fields.

The headlights lit up the rain. At the far end of the track they lit the back of a white van. Low on its left-hand

door a round reflector, screwed on at an angle, shone red.

Only one van in the village had a reflector like that. It was Jean Castagnet's. That week he had written to the town hall that there was hardly any water at his duck hut. He had his water now. The ducks would have come down onto it, so he would be in the hut, in the cellar under the trapdoor, wearing the long rubber boots he hunted in. If she opened the gate, the river would cover that trapdoor.

The trapdoor was twenty-five minutes away, on foot, in the dark, with the dip under water. The bank had ten.

She took out her phone. It had his number in it because of the gate. The screen said 02:51.

His number rang once and nobody answered. She didn't wait for the second ring. She ended the call and put the phone in her pocket. Then she took the handle in both hands and turned it.

She turned it faster than it had ever been turned. At some point the catch slipped. The handle spun backwards through her right fist and tore a line of skin out of her palm. She caught it and kept turning. The gate came up. Under her feet the river went through the opening with a noise she had never heard it make, and out on the fields the dark ground began to shine.

She went back to the van and sat in it with her hand in her lap. At the end of the track the reflector went on shining in her headlights for four more minutes. Then the water rose up the door and covered it, and the red light went out.

She kept the torch on the pillar of the gate. Eighty over the line. Sixty. The sheet of water on the bank shrank to a thin line. By 4 no house in the Port had water in it. Behind the shutters nobody had even woken up.

The cellar came later, at first light. There was a boat. There was the trapdoor, with the torch shining down through it. The water was black and still and came up to the second step of the ladder. Under the water the torch found the sole of a rubber boot.

Only the priest knew she had looked down the track first. She had told him in the confession box, while a bucket in the aisle caught the drips.

* * *

Now Maylis was back under her own lampshade with Inguma on her chest. The clock radio said 04:57.

The brown leaves and the rivets were just under her chin.

On her night Lesca had forty houses to open the gate for. She also had Coralie's car in that yard.

Inguma got down.

On Tuesday Maylis had written out her own Friday night as a job. The handle was near the top, with the trapdoor under it. Lesca had done hers in that order.

Maylis's phone was on the chest of drawers. Jeannot's number was in it, because of the gate. It was Friday morning. Jeannot was down there in his hut.

At 5 she pressed Jeannot's number.

It rang once. She kept the phone to her ear. It rang a second time, then a third. She sat on the edge of the bed with her forearm pressed against her side and let it ring. Across the landing a floorboard creaked. The phone rang nine times.

'Who's dead?' said Jeannot.

She heard the trapdoor go up, then wings, hundreds of them, lifting off the water.

'Nobody. It's Maylis Lesca.'

'One. It's 5 in the morning. Two. I had three hundred ducks sitting on water that I waited two weeks for. Your phone has just scared off every one of them, and they won't come down again before tonight. Three is the village. It drains my water on a Monday. It sends a girl to my kitchen with a pot of flowers on a Sunday. And at 5 on a Friday morning it rings a man in a hole in a field to ask if he's in. Four is your father. For thirty years he raised that gate four turns less than he was told, to leave a man his water, and he never rang me once. He'd have cut his hand off first. You've got his key and none of his sense. Five is the association, and for that I go back to 1962, when they dug their gate where my grandfather had his hut and gave the handle to a Larrère.' He took a breath. 'And six. Bugger off.'

At 5:10 she went down to the kitchen, turned the shopping pad over on the table and changed her own plan. She crossed out the line about the trapdoor and wrote it again at the top, above the key, with *before dark* after it.

Lesca's mother stood in the doorway of the mayor's office in her coat, with her bag on her arm.

'I said I'd never set foot in here,' she said.

It was 9 on Friday morning and Lesca was at her desk in the town hall. Her mother hadn't been inside the building since the day the truck came for her ponies. Lesca had signed the gravel company's contract at this desk. The company had taken her mother's field with the rest, and the flood fields were a lake now. Arlette came three steps into the office and looked around it once, at the desk, at the green safe and at the window, where the back of the stone showed.

Behind her the secretary had the visitors' book open and her pen ready.

'Don't put me in that,' Arlette said.

'I write down every visitor.'

'Then write that I never voted for her to be in here. I've voted for Larrère against her three times. I don't like the man. He drives through my yard as if it was the road. But I voted for him, and I'll say so while I'm standing in here. Write that. Leave my name off.' She waited until the pen was down.

Lesca had won all three times.

'Sit down,' Lesca said.

'I've got my coat on.' Arlette kept hold of her bag. 'Coralie rang me again last night. She rings at 9, when I've got my shoes off, and the phone's in the passage, on the tiles. She says you're planning something for tonight. She doesn't know what, and neither do I. But I know what my mother's words were for. She said them so she could stay in her own bed till morning, and you're using them to leave yours.'

'I heard what you said about a night's sleep.'

'You wanted a whole day off Inguma, and you had one. I sat by that bed from noon on Saturday till breakfast on Sunday. Your hand was colder than on the Monday. What did you give it to count?'

'The lake,' Lesca said. 'Every stone the gravel company has taken out of it. Each load is weighed, so the loads are in a book.'

‘My field,’ Arlette said. She had counted her ponies up the ramp of that truck.

She looked at Lesca’s hands on the desk. ‘Sleep on your side, Maylis. Tonight. With your knees up, so it has nowhere to sit.’

Over there Castagnet would be at the end of the track tonight. Lesca had left her own Castagnet there. She was going over to get the other one out.

‘I’m going across tonight,’ Lesca said. ‘And I won’t be brought back.’

‘I’m not asking where,’ Arlette said. ‘I want you at my table at 7 in the morning. Before the prefect gets you.’

She walked out past the secretary and down the steps. She had been in the building five minutes. Lesca watched her cross the square towards the church. Arlette went around the new stage with her face turned away from the names on the stone.

* * *

At 11 Lesca was standing on the stage in the square, on the cross of white tape that marked her place beside the stone. The young man who had stuck it there had come from the prefecture at Pau, with a clipboard and a roll of tape, to take her through tomorrow’s ceremony. It would be her twelfth. He read it to her off his sheet, from the anthem to the photograph.

‘A point of order,’ Lesca said. ‘You have the flowers as one item and the kiss as the next. They’re one item. Madame Castagnet lays the flowers and stands up, and the mayor kisses her on the left cheek, because your photographer stands on the left. That item has been carried eleven times. This year the widow has given notice against it, so you can take the kiss off your sheet.’

He looked at his sheet. He left the kiss on it.

‘And the medal isn’t an item. It comes on the coat. Your office rings every December to tell me which side.’

The last line on his sheet was the reception, in the big tent on the bank at the Port. The tent went up on the plots where four houses had stood.

Monsieur Darrigrand had come up from the Port with a broom over his shoulder and was standing at the foot of the stage. He used to live in one of the four. A doorstep was all that the State’s contractor had left of his house, and he kept it swept.

‘The tent goes on the plots, Monsieur Darrigrand, as it does every year,’ Lesca said. ‘The State’s new bank went through four houses. It was thirty-six houses and the care home against four.’

‘It’s four when you’re the one counting,’ he said. He leaned on the broom. ‘When it’s your house it’s one, and

they knock it down. Put your tent up. All I ask is that nobody puts a glass down on my step.'

The young man looked down his sheet for a step. Darrigrand put the broom back over his shoulder.

'You're holding on to that stone, Madame le maire,' he said. 'I've watched you up there eleven Decembers. You never needed to before.'

Lesca took her hand off the stone. Darrigrand went down the road to the Port.

'Which one is his?' the young man said.

'The one that's been swept.'

He wanted the front row for the councillors and the emergency services, because it looked better on camera.

'The front row belongs to the care home,' Lesca said. 'It does every year.'

Coralie had come up from the Port with the list. In this village she was the one who ran the care home.

'The emergency services can stand,' she said. 'Mine can't.'

She took the tape from the young man without asking.

'And Madame le maire will sit down on the edge of that stage,' she said. 'She's the colour of this tape.'

Lesca stayed standing. Coralie walked along the front of the stage and pressed strips onto the ground, one wheelchair's width apart, while he followed her and counted them out loud.

'Eight of them were in their beds that night,' Coralie said. 'Madame Etcheto. She says she heard the river go away, like a bath emptying. Monsieur Daguerre, the baker. He'll call out "Here" when the prefect reads out the date. He does it every year.'

'Can he be asked not to?'

'You can ask him. He was asked in 2019, and he said "Here".' She tore off another strip. 'The two Lassalle sisters. Madame Poey, who doesn't know what year it is now but knows that one.'

She pressed down the eighth strip.

'Eight,' the young man said.

'There were forty-two in their beds that night. The others have died since then, in those beds, of the things people die of.'

He stopped counting.

‘There were two of us working that night,’ Coralie said. ‘Nadine’s in the third row and I’m in the second.’ She gave him back his tape. ‘Madame Etcheto goes at this end, nearest the stone, because she asks for that place. Mark it on your plan.’

He marked it.

* * *

When Lesca got home that evening, Coralie’s car was already in the yard. The kitchen was dark, but there was a light on the landing.

She went up. Coralie was standing in the bedroom doorway with the speech in her hand, four typed sheets clipped together.

‘You left this on the kitchen table,’ she said, ‘and I’ve read it. I’d never read it before. I’ve only heard it, eleven times, from the second row.’

‘It’s the same every year. I change the date.’

‘I know. I could say it along with you.’ Coralie turned to the third sheet. ‘*Jean Castagnet was at his duck hut that night, as he was on any night of the season. No one came to tell him.*’ She read it in a flat voice. ‘Every December you say that into a microphone. It’s true, every word of it. And every December I stand there in my good coat and think about your phone.’

Lesca left her coat half off.

‘The morning after,’ Coralie said. ‘The 12th. I finished my shift at 7, and you came in at 9 in your wet clothes and got onto this bed with your boots on and your hand wrapped in a dish towel. Your phone was on the chest of drawers, with the battery nearly dead. I picked it up to put it on the charger, and the screen was open at the list of calls. Incoming, a landline number, no name. Then outgoing. Castagnet J., mobile. Not answered. 02:51.’

She looked up.

‘2:51,’ she said. ‘I’ve known that for twelve years.’

Lesca looked at the top of the wardrobe.

It was 6:45 in the evening. On top of the wardrobe there was a folded blanket, and dust. Nothing was sitting there.

‘You shout at it in the night,’ Coralie said. ‘Across the landing I look at my watch, and it’s always that time.’

For eleven years I told myself it was a coincidence. I'm trained. I know what a coincidence is.'

'You never asked,' Lesca said.

'No.'

'Why not?'

'Because you'd have told me.' Coralie sat down on the edge of the bed, on the side that used to be hers. 'I was in there. I was working nights that week. The shifts were on the fridge door, and you'd read them. There were two of us working, and only a few in those beds who could have walked out. At 2:30 water was coming in under the back door and I was putting down towels. By 4 it had stopped coming, and at breakfast they told me what had been done. So for twelve years I've had two answers. Either you opened it for forty houses, and I live with the mayor. Or you opened it because I was in that building. Then his death is mine as well, and I've stood beside his widow for eleven Decembers. I've never wanted to hear which one it was. Don't tell me now. If I'd asked, I'd have had the answer in the house with us, at every meal. I wanted you in the house, and I thought I could have you without it, if I kept a landing between us.'

'It rang once.'

'The phone doesn't say how long it rang. It says not answered.' She put the speech down on the blanket. 'That's all I've got. You rang him, so you thought he might be out there. I don't know what you saw, and I don't want you to measure it out for me now. I'm telling you I've known that much since the morning after. I've had it with me in the next room, and you've had the rest by yourself. You didn't have to.'

Lesca's right hand had closed into a fist. When she opened it the scar was there, where it had been since the night of the dish towel. She sat down on the bed, on the other side of the four sheets.

'I thought one person knew,' she said. 'And he's not allowed to speak.'

'The priest.'

'Yes.'

'Then there are two of us. And nobody's told me I can't speak.' Coralie didn't touch her. 'You're going somewhere tonight. I've sat beside this bed three times with the phone in my hand, and by now I know what you look like when you've gone. Who is it for?'

'For a man who hasn't drowned yet. There are two of me after all. The other one still holds the key to that gate, in a Peyrebarthe where the river comes up tonight. I'm going to get him out.'

'I thought it might be. It's twelve years too late for anybody here.' She looked at the third sheet. 'Read that line on Saturday or take it out, Madame le maire. It's your speech. You voted for it. But I'll be in the second row,

and I'll know which you did.'

She went across the landing and left her door open.

Lesca stayed on the bed with the speech and tried to say the answer out loud.

'I opened it for forty houses.'

It sounded like a line from the council's minutes. She had said it too many times to hear whether it was true.

'I opened it for Coralie.'

That sounded no more true, and no less.

She had the sum. Forty houses, forty-two beds, a car in the yard of the care home and a van at the end of a track. She tried to remember what she had been thinking when she made it, but all she could remember was turning the handle.

She read the two sentences on the third sheet again. Then she clipped the four sheets back together, as they had been typed.

At 10 she got into bed the way her mother had told her to, on her side with her knees up.

She was facing her open door. Across the landing Coralie's was open too, four steps away, with the lamp on inside. Its light reached the foot of Lesca's bed.

'If I come in and you're lying there with your eyes open,' Coralie said, from across the landing, 'I'm ringing the hospital in Bayonne.'

Lesca didn't answer. She watched the light until the church clock struck 11. It was still on.

Her own roof was dry. Over there it would be raining on forty houses with their shutters closed.

'It's the tide,' she said, too low to cross the landing. In this room it came out.

Then she straightened her legs and turned onto her back.

At 11 on Friday morning Maylis let herself into the town hall, out of the rain. The printer had put out one sheet, from the prefecture at Pau. *Flood watch, river Adour, orange.*

She put the sheet in the mayor's tray and picked up the phone on the secretary's desk.

One woman couldn't raise the floodgate and also get Jeannot up out of his duck hut. She had tried the café first, but the nine who had signed on Tuesday had watched Jeannot's hand go up. A vote was a vote. So she rang the town hall at Hontaube, the next village. She asked to borrow its outdoor workers for one night, at the Port. Hontaube had two. Peyrebarthe had her.

'Who's calling?' the woman at Hontaube said.

'The keyholder. At Peyrebarthe.'

'Oh, you're the one with the gate.' She sounded pleased. 'Is this a request, or a notification?'

'A request,' Maylis said.

'Has your mayor made it?'

'I'm making it.'

'Then it isn't one yet,' the woman said. 'A loan of staff goes from mayor to mayor. There's a form, and I can post you one. It needs his signature and ours.'

'When would you post it?'

'Monday.'

'It's for tonight,' Maylis said.

'Then it should have gone last Monday.'

A hand went over the phone. Behind it Maylis heard a man's voice, then a second, then a chair being pushed back.

'They say they'd come,' the woman said. 'They've got their coats, but I've told them they can't. The agreement

between the two villages starts on 1 January, and before that our men aren't insured on your side. If one of them hurts his back on your bank tonight, nobody pays him for it. From 1 January you won't need a form. You'll belong to us.' She said it kindly. 'I'll post it today anyway, so you have it.'

She hung up.

* * *

Larrère spent ten minutes in the town hall. When he came out he had the orange warning in his coat pocket and his cardboard folder held over his head. Maylis was standing on the steps, between him and his car.

'Pau's sent an orange warning,' she said.

'Pau has sent an orange warning, and Pau doesn't own that gate. The association owns it, and its president says it stays shut. You'll take the van down at dusk and stay by the gate. All night. Keep your phone on the dashboard, charged, and touch nothing until I ring.'

'Water's coming through the bank at the patch. There are forty-two people in the care home, right under that bank, and most of them can't walk.'

'They have staff,' Larrère said. 'It's orange. Red is when people are moved, and I haven't had red. If you raise that gate tonight, you put the river over whatever's standing on those fields.'

'And if the bank breaks?'

'It leaks. It has leaked before, with the river over the line, and it held. Your father slept on that platform with the gate locked shut, and he never rang me once.'

He brought the folder down and turned it, so that she could read her name on the label.

'I have a letter in here in your handwriting. It's your resignation, with a gap where the date goes. If that gate moves tonight before I ring, the letter gets tomorrow's date. You know what's under the letter.'

'I saw your car on 1 December,' Maylis said. 'At dusk, in the lane behind the Castagnet house, with its lights off. Jeannot had gone down to his hut.'

He didn't put the folder back over his head. The rain ran down his forehead.

'I'd be up that lane every night of the year if she'd let me,' Larrère said. 'She has the kitchen door open before I've switched the engine off. Nobody else in this village has ever opened one before I knocked.'

He went down the steps past her and got into his car. The window came down its usual few centimetres.

‘Stay by the gate,’ he said through the gap. ‘You’ll hear from me.’

The window went up.

* * *

There was no sand in the shed. Behind the village hall, though, there was a bin of it, kept for icy roads. Kévin was standing at the bin when she got there. Nobody had asked him to come. He held the bags open while she shovelled with her left arm. He kept each one wide. Most people let a bag fall shut.

‘I was up the ladder on Tuesday when he held that sheet against his car window,’ he said. ‘That was my name, wasn’t it? Is it the eels?’

‘It’s for the eels. Four winters of them.’

‘What’s that, six months?’ He tied the neck of a bag. ‘I’d do them, Maylis. I want you to know I would. Don’t keep a gate shut for me.’

She went on shovelling. The sand filled seventeen bags, which he carried to her van.

At 4 Maylis took the bags down to the back door of the care home. The door opened onto the yard, at the end of the building nearest the bank.

The bank rose above the yard wall. Through the open door Maylis could see down the whole length of the building. The old wing came first. At its far end a ramp went up to a fire door, which stood open. Beyond that was the main corridor, where the night shift had lined up the wheelchairs. Each one had a folded blanket on the seat and a name on a strip of tape. The minibus was at the other end of the building, in the front yard.

Coralie had the list on a cord around her neck. Every name in the building was on it, each with a letter beside it to show whether that person walked, used a frame or was carried. She was going down the line. At each chair she pressed the tape flat with her thumb, read the name against her list and turned the blanket so that it would open towards the door. Maylis stood on the step with a bag of sand held against her good side and watched Coralie do eleven chairs before she looked up.

‘I’ve put the ones who can walk nearest the front,’ Coralie said. ‘If the siren goes, Bixente fills the minibus, takes them up to the village hall and comes back for more. I haven’t timed it in water.’

‘It doesn’t have enough seats for that,’ Maylis said.

‘It has enough seats when nobody’s counting,’ Coralie said.

‘Seven minutes up, in the dry,’ Bixente said. ‘I did it for bingo night.’

Twelve seats and forty-two people made four trips. That was an hour, in the dry.

‘Then take them up now,’ Maylis said. ‘All of them, while it’s light.’

‘I asked at noon. The director rang Pau, and Pau said orange. On orange nobody leaves the building. On red Sarthou sounds his siren, and I move them.’ Coralie lifted the list on its cord. ‘This is as far as I go without a siren. I’m a care assistant, Maylis. I’ve got a corridor full of chairs and a name on every one, on the word of a woman who cuts roadsides.’

Madame Etcheto was sitting in the last wheelchair, at the top of the ramp, with her coat buttoned over her nightdress and her handbag on her knees.

‘You got stuck halfway through the words on bingo night,’ she said to Maylis. ‘I said the rest of them for you, over my duck.’

‘I heard.’

‘So did Inguma. It comes to my room at night. Tonight they want me out here in a chair, and it won’t know where to find me.’

Maylis laid the bags across the bottom of the door with their open ends folded underneath, the way Sarthou laid his. Madame Etcheto counted each one out loud as it went down.

‘Seventeen,’ she said. ‘That’s not many.’

‘There are more on the gendarme’s step,’ Maylis said.

Madame Etcheto folded her hands on her handbag. ‘I won’t sleep in a chair. I’ve slept in room twelve since I came here, and I’ll make them put me back at 10.’

Coralie came out onto the step with Maylis and pulled the door almost shut behind her.

‘Something’s been on your mind since this morning,’ she said. ‘It isn’t on the pad. I looked. Don’t tell me now. I’ve got all of them to think about until 7.’

Maylis hadn’t meant to say it on a doorstep, with the bank over their heads. But she might not get another chance, and that frightened her more than asking did.

‘Come back across the landing.’

Coralie stood still.

‘Say it again.’

‘I’m asking. Come back across.’

‘I told you I’d come if you asked.’ Coralie’s voice shook. ‘I finish at 7 in the morning. I’ll carry the pillow across myself. Be in the house.’

* * *

By 5 Maylis was up on the bank, with the village van parked facing the gate. The river was over the red line. It had gone the colour of the sky, and it was very wide. It went past just under the boards of the platform.

On her other side, far below, the flood fields were under a few centimetres of rainwater. The track ran across them for a kilometre, out to the hunters’ huts.

Jeannot’s white van came along the bank from the Port with its headlights on. It stopped beside hers, door to door, and Jeannot rolled his window down.

‘You rang me at 5 this morning,’ he said.

‘I wanted to hear you answer.’

‘You heard me.’ Jeannot wasn’t laughing. ‘What are you sitting here for?’

‘I’ve been told to stay by the gate, by the phone. And keep it shut.’

‘Then I’m dry.’ He pointed his chin at the fields. ‘The river over the line on that side, and a hand’s width of water on my side. That’s what a bank is for.’

He was above ground, an arm’s length from her window. It was still daylight.

Maylis got out. With the key on her belt she unlocked the padlock on the platform, then the box under the rail. The handle was lying in the box on a cloth. She lifted it out with her left hand and fitted it in place. It went on with a knock.

A hundred metres back along the top of the bank, Larrère’s car was sitting with its engine running and its window up.

She leaned her weight on the handle. The chain came up out of the water one link at a time until it was tight, and the catch dropped into its first tooth with a click. The gate hadn’t moved yet. Eighteen turns would lift it off the stone. The nineteenth would need her shoulder. After that the handle would turn freely and the gate would go all the way up, in daylight, while Jeannot was standing on the bank behind her.

A van door slammed.

Jeannot came up the steps onto the platform in his rubber boots.

‘That’s my hut you’d be filling,’ he said. ‘I waited two weeks for water on it, and you’d put the river in my cellar up to the trapdoor. You were at the counter on Tuesday. You heard the vote, and my hand was up.’

‘The river comes through tonight.’

‘So you say. He says shut.’ He pointed his chin along the bank at the car. ‘I’ve never been on that man’s side of anything in my life. Today I am, so I want to know exactly where I stand. It’s your hand on the handle. Which is it going to be? Shut, or open?’

The river went by under the boards.

Larrère’s car hadn’t moved. Jeannot stood on her boards.

‘Either,’ Maylis said.

‘Then it’s shut,’ Jeannot said. ‘That’s how the vote left it.’

He was off the platform and down the steps before she could take it back.

She lifted the handle off. The catch let go of its one tooth, and the chain went loose and sank back into the water. She put the handle back on its cloth and locked the box.

Larrère’s car turned around in three moves and drove up the hill towards the village. At the last four houses its lights left the road and went in behind them, along the back lane. The Castagnet house was one of the four.

Jeannot had his engine running when she got to his window.

‘Don’t ring tonight, and don’t knock,’ he said. ‘My phone stays in the van, because I won’t have it going off in the hut a second time. And don’t come down in that van. The track’s soft at the dip, softer than where I got stuck, the winter you towed me out. You’d sit there till Easter.’

He looked down the track, with both hands on the wheel.

‘It’s a hole in a field,’ he said. ‘I know what it is. But I light the stove and lock the trapdoor, and nobody can get at me till it’s light. Not him, not the café, not my own kitchen. You’ve got your shed. Leave me my hole.’

The white van went down off the bank onto the track. She turned her own van a quarter turn, so that her headlights pointed after him.

The headlights lit up the rain. They lit the back of the white van as it went away down the track, throwing up mud. Low on its left-hand door the round reflector, screwed on at an angle, shone red.

She looked at it, looked away at the pillar and looked at it again. In a dream it would have changed. It hadn't.

She watched the reflector all the way. It got smaller until it stopped, where the track ended. When his lights went off, hers were the only ones shining on it. A torch came on low down beside the van. Then it went under the ground.

She turned the van back towards the gate. From the top of the bank she could see Coralie's back door, across Sarthou's roof. It was open onto the yard. Coralie was standing in the light from it with her arms folded, looking up at the bank. Then she went in, and the door shut behind the sandbags. Seventeen bags, thirty metres from the patch.

* * *

At 5:30 the light was nearly gone. Maylis left her phone on the dashboard, where she had been ordered to keep it. She shut the van door and went down off the bank on foot.

She walked on the grass between the wheel tracks, which were full of water to the top. Her rib let her walk, but no faster. At the dip the track was under water from one side to the other. She went through it with the water halfway to her knees. Jeannot was right about the van.

The white van was parked where the track ended. Beyond it the hut was a low bump in the tall grass, with a chimney pipe smoking in the rain.

She knocked on the trapdoor with her left fist.

A lock slid back. The trapdoor lifted a hand's width and stopped. In the gap she saw lamplight and one eye. She could smell his stove.

'I told you not to.'

'I walked,' Maylis said.

'I can see how you came.' The eye went to her boots, then past her, along the empty track. 'Who's at the gate?'

'It'll be ninety over the line by 3, Jeannot. The bank goes at the patch. When it does, that gate has to come up, and four minutes after that this trapdoor is under the river.'

'Pau gives less than that for high tide,' Jeannot said. 'I heard it on the radio. Who gave you ninety?'

'I was told.'

'You were told what's under my floorboards. You were told the way to my kitchen as well.' The gap got narrower. 'The gate's shut. Larrère's told you shut, and with it shut I'm sitting in the driest hole in the village.'

I'm not coming up out of it for a number. Go back to your gate. If that phone rings on your dashboard while you're standing here, he'll have your job for it, and I won't write you a letter.'

The trapdoor came down. The lock slid across underneath it.

She knocked two more times. The chimney pipe went on smoking.

She walked back with the rain behind her. It was dark by the time she reached the dip, so she crossed it by the sound of the water.

On the dashboard her phone showed two missed calls from G. Larrère, at 17:50 and 18:15. Under them was one message.

Where were you? I'll ring again tonight. Be in that van.

* * *

Kévin was on the platform by the gate with a torch in his teeth, pulling a net up out of the water, hand over hand. The net was green and as fine as a stocking. It was empty.

'Nobody nets with the river over the line,' he said, around the torch. 'It would take the net, and me after it. I'm bringing my nets in.'

He dropped the net into a cool box and took the torch out of his mouth.

'The café says you've got a mayor inside you. Did she have a night like this one?'

'She had a van at the end of the track,' Maylis said. 'Not yours. Jeannot's.'

'That's something.' Then he saw her face, and the river going by at the height of the boards. 'What else did she have?'

'Nobody. She was by herself. How many seats has your van got?'

'Me and one,' Kévin said. 'And the boxes.'

'Castagnet's in his hut, at the end of that track, with the trapdoor locked. I've been down, and he won't come up for me.'

'Would he come up for me? I'm in three of his letters.'

Kévin could turn the handle while she went back down for Jeannot. If that gate moved, Larrère would send the sheet with Kévin's name on it. Kévin had said he would do the six months. She wasn't going to have him turn

the handle that would send him to prison.

From the top of the bank she could see Coralie's back door, shut, with the light on over it. The minibus had twelve seats.

'Take the van down to the care home, to the front yard,' Maylis said. 'Coralie's working tonight, and she's short of seats.'

'And him?'

'He's mine.'

'It's still orange,' Kévin said. 'What do I say I've come for?'

'Say I sent the van,' Maylis said.

'Those boxes are full of the eels I netted before the river got to the line. They're for a buyer in Irun, and I've got the pump running to keep them alive. Do I turn it off? Will they mind it, at the care home?'

'Leave it running.'

He lifted the two cool boxes over the rail and strapped them into his van.

'I'm staying awake tonight,' Maylis said.

His van drove off the bank towards the Port with the pump running in the back. She could hear it all the way down to the yard.

* * *

At 10 that night the phone lit up on the dashboard with a message from Coralie.

Etcheto back in 12. Walked there on my arm. Said her words.

Maylis wrote back. *Not 12 tonight. Put her at the front.*

Asleep. I'm not waking a woman of 94 for orange. Keep asking me things.

Maylis didn't ask a second time. She read the last four words again. Then she counted the hours to 7.

She switched off the headlights. On her right the river went by, close under the top of the bank, with a sound like a crowd far away. On her left Jeannot was sitting in his cellar. Behind her, under the bank, were Sarthou and the Darrigrands' baby and old Bordenave, and the rest of the forty houses with their shutters closed. And there was Coralie, with every name on her list. All that kept the river off them was a bank that cost the village

four wheelbarrows of clay a year.

At 11 she rang Jeannot's number. It rang in a van at the end of the track, where nobody could hear it. She let it ring nine times.

She got out and went to the platform, under its lamp. She unlocked the box, lifted out the handle and fitted it in place, and it went on with the same knock. She leaned on it until the chain was tight and the catch dropped into its first tooth. Then she came down and locked the padlock on the platform behind her, as she had every night for eighteen years.

She kept her back to the track while she did it.

Back in the van she did what she had told Lesca she would do. She put the seat upright, held the phone against her knee with the screen up and set herself to stay awake. It was a night's overtime, by order of the president. He would argue about every hour of it.

The river was high and the patch was leaking, but the bank had leaked before and held. She had to be awake at 2:51.

The screen said 23:34.

Then the screen said 01:12. She hadn't seen it change. She got out and walked to the gate and back in the rain. There was still time to go down the track and knock. But the dip had been halfway to her knees at dusk, and the river was higher now. If she was down there at 2:51, nobody would be at the gate. She got in again, wet, and rolled the window down to let the cold in. When her head dropped forward, she pushed her thumbnail into the cut on her palm and kept it there.

02:49. She was awake. She laid her left hand on the steering wheel and touched each finger in turn. She counted five.

At 2:51 something heavy landed on the roof of the van. The metal bent in over her head and sprang back. Then Inguma was inside, between her and the windscreen, sitting on her chest with its leaves against the steering wheel. She couldn't lift a finger.

It was an hour and nine minutes short of 4.

In her hand, the phone began to ring.

She pushed. The breath went through the crack in the rib. Inguma pressed down just as hard. But the seat under Maylis was still the seat of the van, and there was rain on the windscreen.

The phone rang a second time. Each breath stopped halfway down. She took one breath for each ring and pushed.

Three. Over Inguma's back she could see the lamp on the platform and the handle where she had left it.

Four. Its steel back was cold against her raincoat. She pushed.

Five. Her mouth tasted of coins.

On the sixth ring the breath wouldn't come. She had nothing to push with. The phone went on ringing in a hand she couldn't close.

The arms of the chair were warm.

Lesca was in the chair in the steel room, with Maylis beside her. Maylis got up first, and Lesca stood up after her.

Both lamps on the panel were lit. The wall on Lesca's right was gone again. Where it had been she could see the lit hall and its rows of tables. One chair in the hall was empty, with a card laid in front of it, and the name on the card was hers.

Maylis faced her in the yellow raincoat, with rain on its shoulders and mud up to the ankles of her boots. Her right forearm was pressed across her side. The palm of her right hand was bandaged.

Lesca opened her own right hand and held it out between them. The scar ran across the palm, white, from the base of the forefinger to the bottom of the palm.

Maylis looked at it for a long time.

'You rang once,' Maylis said.

It was Lesca's own voice. It sounded the way the town hall's answering machine played it back to her.

Lesca had answers. For twelve years she had given them to the prefect, to her council and to Maïté. Every one of them was true. She closed her hand and didn't give any of them.

'I asked you not to come,' Maylis said. 'You came, and you brought the river with you. But my bank's still standing. If I get you out of me now, it may hold. You're not staying.'

'I've come to stay,' Lesca said.

Far off, the phone had rung until it stopped. Now it started again, and Maylis turned her head towards the sound.

Lesca sat back down in the chair.

The phone woke Maylis in the van, behind the steering wheel, and Lesca woke there with her.

The van was parked on top of the bank, facing the floodgate. Rain was running down the windscreen. Ahead, under the lamp on the platform, the handle was in place, with the chain pulled tight. The clock on the dashboard

said 02:52. The phone was ringing in the left hand.

One ring.

The right hand moved before anything else did. It was Maylis's. It took hold of the steering wheel at the top.

Lesca had the rest: the legs, the left hand and the mouth. She dropped the phone in the lap, reached across with the left hand and turned the key. The engine started. She put the lights on.

Two.

Lesca put the van in first gear with the left hand, got the hand back on the wheel and let the van roll along the top of the bank. The lamp and the handle went by the side window. Then they were behind her.

Three.

Where the track began Lesca turned the wheel. The right hand pulled it the other way, with the cracked rib behind it, and lost. The headlights swung out across the flood fields and down the wheel tracks. At the far end a round reflector shone red.

Four.

Lesca kept the foot down. The right hand still had the top of the wheel and was hanging its whole weight on it, so she drove against the weight.

Five.

The right hand let go of the wheel and covered the eyes. Lesca kept the foot down, blind. She took the right wrist in the left hand and dragged it off the face. By then the front of the van had swung away from the track, towards the drop, so she let go of the wrist to catch the wheel.

That freed the right hand. It pulled the handbrake up as far as it would go.

The engine struggled and died. The van stopped where the track left the bank, with its front wheels on the slope. The stop threw the body forward onto the steering wheel, and the horn sounded once across the fields.

Six.

'Let go of it,' Lesca said, with the mouth. 'I left a man at the end of that track. I can get this one out. I know where the dip is. Let me drive.'

She went for the handbrake with the left hand. The right hand was locked on it, cut palm and all. She pulled at its fingers. The hand on the brake was the weaker, and it had got there first.

Maylis took the jaw from her for three words.

‘You’re the water.’

Seven.

On Sunday night, standing in the steel room, Lesca had tried to call it the tide, and the word hadn’t come. She had the jaw back now and nothing to put in it. Maylis took it again.

‘Inguma, enauk hire beldur.’

Lesca waited for Either. It didn’t come.

‘You’ll count the fingers of my right hand,’ Maylis said. ‘Then you’ll take her home.’

There were five of them, locked on the brake. It was a short count.

Something heavy landed on the roof of the van. The metal bent in and sprang back. Then Inguma was inside. Its leaves went over the knuckles of the right hand on the brake, one at a time. After the fifth it was on the chest, with its back to her and its leaves against the windscreen.

Eight.

Lesca knew what came next. First the weight, then her own bed, with one pillow on it and a dry roof over it.

She wasn’t going. She got the left hand onto the steering wheel, under the leaves, and locked the arm. For twelve years she had gone wherever that weight took her. The cold went through the raincoat and into the cracked rib, and the arm began to shake. She kept it where it was.

She knew what that cost. She had seen the card with her name on it.

Rain was loud on the roof of the van. She had crossed for that sound, and for a bed with two pillows. She held on to the wheel for the whole of that ring.

Then she saw what she was holding. It was the wheel of a van with a dead engine and its brake on. The hand on the brake was the hand that had held the stair post against her. It wasn’t going to open while she was in this body, and she couldn’t open it with one hand of her own. The clock on the dashboard said 02:53. At the end of the headlights the reflector was red, and it was getting no nearer.

She could stay sitting in this van until the river came over it. As long as she held the wheel, nobody was going down that track at all.

‘I’m letting go,’ Lesca said, with the mouth.

She used it for five more words and heard them come out in Maylis's voice.

'Go to the hut first.'

Then there was no steering wheel, and no rain.

* * *

Lesca was standing barefoot on a waxed wooden floor, under strip lights. Inguma hadn't taken her home. She had held on one ring too long for that. It had put her down where her card was.

Behind her was the steel room, open on its fourth side. The chair in it was empty.

In front of her the tables ran in three rows under the lights, out past the place where the back wall of the village hall should have been and on further than she could see. At every place there was a bingo card and a small dish of corn, and one of the village's dead sat over them with their head down. Nearest were the ones she had known. After them came the ones her father had buried, and after those the ones nobody living had ever met. The hall smelled of floor wax and of the coffee pot. On the edge of the stage there was a duck in white paper, with its feet sticking out.

'Line,' said a woman in the first row. She put her hand up.

The voice at the far end read her numbers back to her, each one whole and then in parts. She was one short. She took her hand down.

One chair was empty, with a card laid in front of it.

'Lesca, Maylis,' the voice called. 'Lesca. Maylis.'

Nobody else looked up. They had their grains of corn ready.

The place was in the second row. The chair next to it was taken. Jean Castagnet sat there in two jackets, with a card in each hand. On the other side a woman lifted her handbag off the empty chair and put it on her knees.

Lesca walked over to him and stopped at his shoulder. He didn't look up from his numbers.

'I saw your van,' she said. 'I rang once.'

He put a grain of corn on a card.

She waited for him to look up. He put a grain on his second card.

'Lesca. Maylis.'

Her hand was on the back of the empty chair. Her knees bent and she sat down.

The voice called a number, whole and then in parts. It was on her card, in the top row. She had a grain of corn between her finger and thumb and was holding it over the square. She put it back in the dish.

‘The mayor of Peyrebarthe sends her apologies,’ she said, in the voice she used for the prefecture. ‘She has a ceremony at 11, and she will not be taking this seat.’

‘Lesca. Maylis.’

‘You can put that in the minutes as apologies received.’

She tried to stand, but her hand stayed on the seat of the chair. The fingers had locked on the wood. She opened them with the other hand.

Then she stood up straight and walked. A hall with no walls had no door, so she took the aisle between the second row and the third. A man in the third row had his arm around his card so that his neighbour couldn’t copy it. Her father was sitting at the end of the second row, with his watch on the paper tablecloth beside his card. He didn’t look up from his numbers. She didn’t stop. The rows went on and on, and behind her the voice went on calling her name.

A long way behind her the dry sound started on the wooden floor. She kept her face turned towards the rows. Then Inguma was on her chest, where she stood, with its leaves under her chin. The strip lights went out, starting from the edges.

It was 2:53 on Saturday morning. Maylis had her body back. She also had five words in her mouth that she hadn't put there.

'Go to the hut first.'

The voice had been her own. Lesca had gone out of her the way warmth goes out of a chair, and those words were what she had left behind. Maylis's left hand was open on the steering wheel. The engine had died. The phone was ringing in her lap. Eight rings so far.

Her right hand was still locked on the handbrake, though nobody was driving her now.

Maylis took her hand off the brake.

The screen said *Castagnet, house*.

She answered.

'You're at the gate,' Larrère said. 'Good. Pau says the river is ninety centimetres over the line and rising. The gate stays shut. You'll stand by it and touch nothing until I ring again. That's an order from the president.'

Behind his voice she could hear a clock ticking, close to the phone, the kind that hangs in a kitchen.

'Castagnet's in his duck hut,' she said.

'He's in his hut, yes. He stays dry as long as you do what you're told.'

He hung up.

She started the engine, backed up onto the bank and drove back past the gate, towards the Port. Two hundred metres beyond the gate, where the road came up, she got out with the torch.

The patch had opened. Water was running down the face of the bank in a sheet as wide as a door. It crossed the road, went over Sarthou's sandbags and on through his hedge. When she put her hand flat on the clay beside the water, the clay moved under her palm.

Lesca was gone. The water kept coming.

Maylis had built that patch herself in April, one wheelbarrow at a time. At 2:55 she gave it ten more minutes.

Jeannot had told her not to bring the van down, and at dusk she had waded through the dip herself. She took the van anyway. In the van she could still have both, Jeannot and the gate. She worked it out as a job. Three minutes to get there. Two to get him up the ladder, if he climbed. Three back. That made eight, and then the handle, with her shoulder under it at the nineteenth turn. Every job on that bank had taken her longer than the time she gave it.

She rang Coralie as she drove.

‘The bank’s going at the patch. You’ve got ten minutes. Start moving them now, and don’t wait for a siren.’

‘Where are you?’ Coralie said.

‘On the bank. Jeannot’s in his hut, with the trapdoor locked. If I open the gate the river’s on him in four minutes.’

‘Then which do you want?’ Behind Coralie somebody was calling a name. ‘The gate, or Castagnet? Say which, Maylis. For once.’

‘Both.’

The line stayed open, but Coralie said nothing.

‘Start at the bank end,’ Maylis said, and dropped the phone on the seat.

The lamp over the platform came up beside her. Under it was the handle, already fitted, with the chain pulled tight. She let the van slow down until the handle was level with her eyes. For three breaths she kept her foot off the pedal.

She drove past.

The van went down off the bank onto the track. The phone on the seat said 02:57. She drove in second gear through wheel tracks full of water, and the rib hurt every time the steering wheel pulled. Rain blew into the headlights. At the far end of their light was the red reflector.

Six hundred metres along, the track dipped. The front of the van went down and stayed down, and the back wheels dug in. The van sat on its belly across the wheel tracks and wouldn’t move.

The phone on the seat began to ring again. The screen said *Castagnet, house*.

She got out into water that came over her boots. The gate was six hundred metres behind her. The red reflector was four hundred metres in front. The bank had six minutes left.

She could be at the handle inside those six minutes, and she knew what they would buy. The river would go out over the fields and stop coming through the patch. The bank end of the care home would stay dry. She had just sent Coralie to the bank end.

She also knew what an open gate did four minutes later at the other end of this track. Down there Jeannot was sitting on a dry floor, under a trapdoor he had locked himself. He wouldn't hear the water until it was over him.

The lamp over the gate was behind her, small and white in the rain. She took a step back towards it. Then a second, and a third.

Under that lamp was the bank. Under the bank was Coralie, who had said 7, and told her to be in the house. Coralie, who had asked her to say which, for once.

If she turned that handle, Jeannot drowned and her hand had done it. If she went on, whatever the river did behind her was the river's doing.

She wanted it not to be her.

Maylis turned her back on the lamp and went on.

She hadn't run since she cracked the rib, and it let her have a third of each breath. Mud to the ankle at every step. The torch in her left hand, her right arm pressed across her side. She counted her steps. The reflector grew in front of her until, at four hundred steps, it was the size of a plate. She passed Jeannot's van. Then her legs found the low roof of the hut.

The trapdoor was shut. She beat on it with the end of the torch.

The trapdoor lifted. A lamp came up under it, then Jeannot's face. Behind his shoulder she could see a concrete room, with a stove burning and a flask on a shelf. The floor was dry.

'I told you not to knock,' he said.

'Come up. I'm opening the gate.'

'You're what?'

'The bank's going at the Port,' Maylis said. 'I'm opening the gate. You've got four minutes after I do, and then this is under water.'

'It's shut. Larrère told you shut. Look at that floor. There isn't a centimetre of water on it. I've got three hundred ducks sitting out there, and you come down here in the middle of the night like your father never—'

She grabbed the collars of both his jackets in her left hand and pulled. He was fifty-eight and heavy. He had the

ladder under his boots and didn't use it to help her. Something gave in her side. She heard it go. He came up over the edge of the trapdoor onto his knees in the mud, swearing, and she didn't let go until he was standing.

'Little Lesca,' Jeannot said. 'You've gone mad.'

'Drive.'

He looked at her in the light of his own lamp. Then he drove.

His van went back along the track faster than she had come down it. He knew every wheel track. At the dip his headlights picked up the front of the village van. It was sunk across the track from edge to edge, with its door hanging open.

He stopped a metre short of it.

'I told you,' he said. 'Not in that van.'

There was no way around it, with the fields under water on both sides. She was out of his van before he had the handbrake on. She took her phone off the seat of the village van as she went past.

Six hundred metres to go. She ran. He came after her and fell behind. Ahead of her was the lamp over the platform, with the handle under it.

She was two hundred metres short of the bank when it broke, at 3:11.

It sounded like a truck tipping out a load of gravel a long way off, except that the sound didn't stop. The street lamps of the Port went out one after another, starting at the bank end.

Maylis had given the bank ten minutes, and it had held for sixteen.

A siren started up at Sarthou's house, the kind you turn by hand.

She climbed onto the top of the bank and pointed the torch at the pillar. Eighty centimetres over the line, and falling as she watched. The river was going down by itself. It was going out through a gap as wide as a house, into the Port.

The handle was still on, where she had left it at 11. She hadn't turned it one centimetre. And Coralie was down there, under the gap.

'Open it now,' Jeannot said behind her. He was out of breath. 'It'll take the weight off.'

She was already running along the top of the bank, towards the lights that were left.

After twenty metres she turned around, unhooked the key from her belt and threw it back to him.

Jeannot caught it against his chest with both hands.

‘That’s for the padlock,’ she shouted. ‘The handle’s on. It sticks at nineteen. Get your shoulder under it.’

She ran. The torch showed her the gravel one step at a time. The river was on her left, close and loud. On her right, down below, there were no street lamps any more. The only light came from further along. It was low down, white and moving.

After two hundred metres the top of the bank ended, at the place where the road had come up from the Port. The water went through the gap in a smooth brown slope and broke at the bottom on what was left of Sarthou’s hedge.

She went down the land side of the bank on her heels, through somebody’s rows of beans, into the water. It came up above her knees.

It was colder than the rain. It was moving away from the gap and down the street, pulling at the backs of her knees. Torch up. Right arm across her side. Whatever had given in her side at the trapdoor now let her have a quarter of a breath at a time, so she breathed fast.

Sarthou’s front door stood open. The river went in through the door and came out through the kitchen window, carrying a chair. The sandbags were gone from his step. He had laid them properly. One of them rolled against her leg in the road.

Sarthou himself was in the street in his cape, up to his waist in water, coming up from the lower houses. He was holding a child above his head, wrapped in a blanket. It was the Darrigrands’ baby, screaming.

‘Number thirty-eight is out,’ he said. ‘They are on the church road with the other child. I have done every door down to thirty-one.’ He was out of breath too. ‘Bordenave is at his upstairs window. He says that he is dry up there and that he is staying.’

‘The care home.’

‘The water went in at that end first. I saw it go.’ He lifted the child higher. ‘3:11. I looked at my watch. That is for the file.’

He turned and went back down the street into the dark, with the baby over his head, shouting the number of the next house.

The care home was the last building before the gap. Its long side faced the street and its short end stood under the bank. That end was dark. The water from the gap was breaking against it as high as the windowsills. The last room at that end was room twelve. At 10 Coralie had walked Madame Etcheto back to it.

At the other end the front yard was lit up. Two vehicles had their headlights pointed at the glass doors.

Maylis walked towards the yard through the water, counting. A rubbish bin floated past on its side. Something soft touched her knee and was gone. After sixty steps the road dipped and the water was at her hips. After a hundred she had the gatepost of the yard in her left hand.

The minibus was parked with its nose to the doors and water over its step. Beside it K vin had driven his van in, opened the rear doors and put two mattresses on the floor. His two blue cool boxes stood on the pavement at the top of the yard, on the high side, where the water hadn't reached. The pump was still running off its battery.

K vin was at the back of the van in his leather jacket, in water above his knees. He was carrying a man in his arms the way you carry a child. He put him down on a mattress, beside a woman who was already lying there, and turned around for the next one.

'How many have gone up?' Maylis said.

He shrugged. 'I've done one trip. Five people. Bixente's done one.' He nodded at the minibus. 'Ask Nadine. I only lift them.'

Inside the glass doors the corridor ran back the whole length of the building. The water in it was halfway to the knees. Wheelchairs stood along one side, each with its strip of tape. In more than half of them somebody was sitting with a blanket around their shoulders and their bare feet up on the footrests, out of the water. They were quiet. They were looking at the headlights.

Nadine was in the doorway with a torch in her fist. Around her neck, on its cord, hung Coralie's list. She read a name off it and took hold of the wheelchair that went with the name.

'Madame Hirigoyen. Frame.'

'Where's Coralie?' Maylis said.

'Down there.' Nadine pointed the torch along the corridor without turning her head. 'You told her the bank end. She hung this on me and went. She sent nine, ten and eleven up the ramp to me in their chairs, and she went back down for twelve. Then the lights went out.'

'And she hasn't come up.'

'I've shouted. You can't hear anything from down there, only water.' Nadine swung the next chair around by one handle and left it in front of Maylis. 'She said the left side, front to back, and they go in the van or the minibus, whichever has room. She said not to stop for anything. She said it twice.'

She went off through the water with Madame Hirigoyen.

Maylis had the handle of the chair in her left hand. Monsieur Daguerre was sitting in it in his pyjamas, with his cap on and both hands on the arms.

‘Here,’ he said.

‘I know you are.’

Beyond the last wheelchair the fire door stood open. The old wing behind it was dark. Coralie was somewhere behind that door. Maylis wanted to let go of the chair and run to it. But between her and the door sat a row of people who couldn’t walk, and she had one of them in her hand.

She pulled him out backwards over the doorstep. The chair dropped into the yard and the water came up to the middle of the wheels. With only one arm to push with, she put her left hand on the left handle and her hip against the back of the seat. The chair went sideways. It kept pulling to the right, and every time she straightened it she lost her quarter of a breath and had to find it again. The headlights were in her eyes. It was fourteen metres to the back of the van. She counted them.

Kévin stood in the water at the back of the van and bent over the chair. He got one arm under the old man’s knees and one behind his back, lifted him and put him in the van. The cap stayed on.

She took the empty chair back through the water and stood it against the wall. At the end of the corridor the fire door was still open. Nobody had come through it. She took the next one.

The next one was a woman she knew by sight from bingo night, who had marked her card with her tongue between her teeth. After her came one of the Lassalle sisters, who wouldn’t let go of her sister’s hand, so Nadine brought the second chair up beside the first and the two went across the yard side by side, with Nadine on one and Maylis on the other. Then there was a man who weighed nothing.

Each time she came back in, she looked down the corridor before she looked for a chair. Once she shouted Coralie’s name down it. The people in the blankets turned their heads towards the fire door with her. When nobody came through it, they turned back to the headlights.

The next man asked her at every metre whether it was Thursday.

‘It’s Saturday.’

‘Then they’ll want the bins out,’ he said.

She was back at the doorstep with his empty chair when Coralie came up through the fire door.

She came up the ramp on the rail, hand over hand, with no torch. She was wet to the collar and had lost a shoe. At the top she stopped, looked along the corridor at the chairs that still had people in them, and counted them.

Maylis's hand had opened. The empty chair went over on its side in the water.

Coralie walked up the corridor past the row. She took the torch out of Nadine's fist, lifted the list from around Nadine's neck and hung it around her own. Then she saw Maylis on the doorstep. She looked at Maylis's side, at the arm held across it, at the water running out of her raincoat. Coralie's mouth opened and shut again.

'Castagnet?'

'He's at the gate,' Maylis said. 'He's out. He was dry.'

'Don't tell me what he was.'

'Twelve,' Maylis said.

'It won't open. The water's pushing on the door from inside the room. I had my shoulder to it, and then my back, and then the torch went and I couldn't—' Coralie looked down at the names. 'I've got a corridor full of people I can reach, and one I can't. Pick that chair up.'

'Did she answer you? Through the door?'

Coralie read out the next name.

Maylis stood the chair on its wheels and went in for the next one.

Bixente was filling the minibus from its other door. It had twelve seats, but he didn't stop at twelve. When it was full he shut the door and sounded the horn once. Coralie drew a line through a block of names with the pencil that hung from the list.

'Seven minutes up the hill, in the dry,' he called.

'Don't give me the minutes. Go.'

The minibus backed out of the yard, pushing a wave in front of it, and turned up the hill. Its headlights left the glass doors.

Maylis leaned against the wall inside the doors. Her legs had stopped telling her where the floor was. When she took the phone out of her chest pocket to see the time, the card from the steel room came out with it. She pushed the card back in. The screen was wet and she had to read it twice. It said 03:31 both times.

The water in the corridor was up to her knees now. And the old wing was lower still, at the bottom of its ramp.

'It's still coming up,' she said.

‘I can see where it is,’ Coralie said. ‘I made a mark on the door frame.’ She didn’t look at the mark. ‘Next. Monsieur Hourcade. Carried.’

There was nobody to carry him. Kévin was at the van and Nadine had a chair.

Jeannot came in from the street, walking through water that broke against his chest. He had no lamp. He came through the yard into the headlights with his arms out for balance and his mouth open.

He reached the doorstep and held on to the door.

‘It’s up,’ he said. ‘Your gate. I counted the clicks, the way you do, and at nineteen it stopped. I got my shoulder under it and it went, and I’ve done something to my knee.’ He got his breath back. ‘3:20, it went up. The river’s on my hut now, and it’s still coming in here.’

He held the key out to her on his palm.

She looked at it. Until tonight it had never been off her belt.

‘I put that handle in letter thirty,’ Jeannot said.

‘I wrote to them too.’

‘I know you did. They took note.’ He pushed his palm at her. ‘It’s no use to anybody now. Have it back.’

She hooked it on her belt.

‘There’s a man in there who has to be carried,’ she said. ‘Hourcade. Halfway down, on the left.’

Jeannot looked down the corridor at the row of faces in the light. He looked for two breaths.

‘I was at school with his son,’ he said.

He went in. When he came out he had Monsieur Hourcade on his back, with the old man’s arms around his neck and his own hands locked under the thin knees. He carried him across the yard in his rubber boots.

They kept going. Maylis pushed the chairs and Jeannot took the ones who couldn’t sit. Nadine brought them up from the back, Coralie read out the names and Kévin lifted.

When the van had its five, Kévin shut the doors on them and drove out of the yard. While he was gone the only light in the corridor was Coralie’s torch, lying on a windowsill. The chairs waited in a row in the dark, with the water moving past their footrests. Maylis stood with her hand on the back of one. The woman in it had taken hold of her sleeve and didn’t let go.

Nobody spoke. Out in the street something big floated by, knocked against the wall and went on. No sound came from the dark end of the corridor.

Then K vin's headlights came down the hill again and across the glass.

He drove up to the doorstep and got out. He took the next one from Jeannot and the one after from Maylis. There were seven chairs left with people in them, and two mattresses. He looked at the seven, then at the floor of the van.

'They'll have to sit up against each other,' K vin said. 'It's that or another trip.'

'There isn't another trip,' Coralie said.

At 4 in the morning he was lifting the fifth when the phone went off in his shirt pocket. It didn't ring. It buzzed twice against his chest.

K vin stood in the water with a woman's wheelchair half up on the back of his van. He put it down level. Then he held his left hand out in front of him, in the light his headlights threw back off the glass, with the fingers spread. He touched each finger with the forefinger of his right hand.

Maylis watched him do it. Her own hand was on a chair.

'Five,' he said.

He looked at the hand a moment longer. Then he put it under the woman's knees and lifted her in.

* * *

By 4:10 the corridor was empty from the front doors to the fire door, except for one chair. Past the fire door a ramp went down into the old wing, which ran on to the end of the building, under the bank. Its lights had gone out with the street lamps.

Coralie stood at the top of the ramp with the list in her hand. Every name on it had a line through it except one. She put the torch between her teeth and took hold of the rail.

Maylis had Madame Poey's chair by its handle. It was the last chair.

K vin came in over the doorstep. He looked at Coralie going down the ramp, then at Maylis, and took the chair from her without asking.

'I've got her,' he said. 'Go on.'

Maylis went down the ramp after the torch.

At the bottom the water came up to her waist, then to her ribs. It pressed against the place that had given in her side and held it, and for the first time since the trapdoor she got half a breath. The water in here was black and still. It smelled of the river and of drains. Ahead of her Coralie's torch moved along the wall at the height of the door handles, from one room number to the next.

Nine was open. The bed had been stripped down to the mattress, which had floated off the frame and was now lying across the room. By the window a walking frame stood in the water with a dressing gown hung over it.

Ten was open. It had two beds, pushed together. The blankets hung down into the water from both.

Eleven was open. Over the bed stood the machine they used for lifting a resident out of it. Its straps hung down, turning a little.

Maylis walked with her left hand on the wall and her boots full of water. She had stood in this corridor once before, with Coralie, outside the last door on the left.

The torch had stopped.

Twelve was shut. The number was on the door in metal. Under it was a card in a holder, with a name written in Coralie's capital letters.

Coralie took the torch out of her mouth and put her shoulder to the door. This time it opened. The water on the other side was level with the water on this side.

She went in. Maylis went as far as the door frame and held on to it.

The window was gone. The whole of it had come in, frame and glass, and was now under the water. Through the hole Maylis could see the foot of the bank, a metre away, with clay running down it. The curtain had been carried across the room and wrapped around the leg of the chair. On the chair hung a coat, buttoned up and wet to the collar.

The bed had been wound up as high as it went. The water was level with the mattress.

It had been higher. It had left a line on the wallpaper a metre above the pillow. It had left mud on the shelf, and on the photographs on the shelf.

Madame Etcheto was in the bed. She was on her back with her hands outside the blanket, as she always was when she said her words. Her handbag was under one hand. Her eyes were open. There was mud at the corner of her mouth.

Coralie laid the torch on the pillow. She took the nearer wrist, put two fingers on the inside of it and looked at her watch. She held it for the full half minute.

Then she laid the hand back on the blanket and closed the eyes with her thumb.

She took the pencil on its cord and drew a line through the last name on the list.

The phone in Maylis's pocket said 04:16. She stood in the doorway with the river up to her ribs and looked at the top of the wardrobe. There was a hatbox on it. Nothing else.

* * *

In the village hall the strip lights were on. Somebody had set out chairs along the folding tables in three rows and switched on the coffee pot.

The old people sat in their blankets with their heads down while Coralie went along the rows with the list. She touched each one on the shoulder, said a number, looked at the list and went on. Maylis stood by the door in her wet clothes, with her arm across her side. Jeannot stood next to her in his rubber boots, dripping onto the waxed floor.

'Thirty-nine,' Coralie said. 'Forty.'

She came to the end of the third row. A man sat in the second chair from the end. She touched him.

The last chair was empty.

'Forty-one,' Coralie said.

Inguma didn't put Lesca down. It held her in the dark with its leaves under her chin. Behind her, in the hall of the dead, the voice went on calling her name.

'Lesca, Maylis. Lesca. Maylis.'

Then the voice called a number, first whole and then in parts.

'Twelve. One, two.'

Somebody pulled a chair in to a table.

It was nearly 6 on Saturday morning when Inguma put her down.

It had taken her home, to her own body. But the body wasn't in her bed. It was on a stretcher against the wall of a corridor, in the hospital in Bayonne. The strip lights above her now were the hospital's. The two fingers on the inside of her wrist belonged to her own Coralie, the one who slept across the landing.

'I came in at 2:55,' Coralie said. 'Your eyes were open, so I rang, the way I said I would. Bayonne has had you for two hours and found nothing. I could have told them that.' She kept her fingers where they were. 'Lie still, Madame le maire. They'll bring a form that says you're leaving against advice, and you'll sign it. I've got the car. You're due in the square at 11.'

Lesca signed it lying down. They drove home with the heater on.

'I rang your mother from the corridor,' Coralie said at the wheel. 'She's had her table laid since 7.'

They reached the village by 9.

* * *

Lesca stood on the cross of white tape with the sash over her good coat. The stone was beside her. The two names on it were level with her right knee.

Below her the care home had the front row. Coralie had brought the residents up in two groups, put their chairs on her strips of tape and given each of them a blanket. Madame Etcheto sat at the end nearest the stone with her handbag on her knees. Her lips were moving. Behind the front row the square was full as far as the church wall,

and people were still coming up the road from the bank. It was more people than had ever voted for Lesca.

Sarthou stood at the bottom of the steps in his uniform, holding the flag upright in its shoulder strap. In this village he had retired, and this was the one day a year he came back to the square.

At 11 Kévin, in the village's yellow raincoat, pushed a cable into the loudspeaker on the town hall steps. The national anthem came out in the middle of a line. He pulled the cable out and pushed it in again, and this time the anthem started from the beginning. The square stood for one verse. In the front row the men who couldn't stand took off their caps. Then Sarthou carried the flag up the steps and stopped behind the stone.

The prefect spoke first. The young man from Pau waited at the bottom of the steps with his clipboard and his watch.

'On the night of 11 to 12 December 2014,' the prefect read.

'Here,' said Monsieur Daguerre, from the front row.

The prefect looked up, then found his line again. It was his second year in the job. He had brought last year's speech. He said that one night a river had asked this village a question, and the village had answered. He said that the State had rebuilt what the river had tried to break, and that the State did not forget its dead. There had been one death, and one was too many. Then, at the place where his sheet told him to, he turned from the microphone and held out his open hand towards Lesca.

'One employee of this village, alone at her post, took in the dark the decision that the hour required. Today she is its mayor.'

A television camera stood on its stand under the first plane tree. When the hand turned to her, the camera did too. She kept her face the way she had kept it at all of these ceremonies. The prefect finished inside his time.

Then the microphone was hers.

The crowd stretched from the stage to the plane trees and on down the road to the Port, where a second loudspeaker gave them each word a moment late. Coralie was in the second row in her good coat, with her hands on the handles of a wheelchair. Maïté stood beside the flowers, in black, holding her bag in front of her. At the foot of the steps, a metre from the stone, stood Larrère, with his association's book under his arm. He kept his hat on.

The speech was typed on four sheets. She had written it in 2015.

'It began to rain on 24 November,' she read, 'and it rained for eighteen days.'

The first sheet was about the rain. She told them about the drains running backwards into the yards. She told them about the fields, under water that had all come from the sky, and about the red line on the pillar of the old

gate, which she had read at 8 every morning. Her voice went out over the square, came back off the church and came a third time from the road to the bank.

The second sheet was about the river. On the night of the 11th it stood ninety centimetres over the red line. Water was coming through the old bank at the Port. Behind that bank were forty houses and a care home with forty-two people in their beds. Eight of the forty-two were sitting a few metres from her knees.

‘The gate on the flood fields was opened,’ she read, ‘and the river went out over three hundred hectares of grass. By first light it had fallen below the doorsteps of the Port.’

She turned to the third sheet, which was about Jean Castagnet. It began with two sentences.

‘Jean Castagnet was at his duck hut that night, as he was on any night of the season.’

The next sentence was six words long. *No one came to tell him.* She had read it into that microphone every December. She had said it to Maïté across a council table, when Maïté had asked her a different question. Every word of it was true, and it was typed.

She looked up from the sheet.

‘I knew he was at his hut,’ she said. ‘When I got to the gate I pointed my headlights down the track, and his van was at the end of it. I knew it was his. I rang his phone, and I let it ring once. Then I opened the gate, and I drowned him.’

The church gave it back to her. The loudspeaker on the bank road said ‘drowned him’ after the square had finished hearing it.

She was on her feet, in daylight, in front of all of them. She got her knees ready to lock. If Inguma was ever going to come for her by day, it would come now. She waited for the weight on her chest and the brown leaves under her chin, but nothing came down on her. There was the wind. The flag moved on its pole. She could turn her head.

In the front row Monsieur Daguerre held his cap in his lap. One of the Lassalle sisters took hold of the other’s hand. Madame Poey, who didn’t know what year it was, said the year of the flood out loud to her blanket. At the end of the row, nearest the stone, Madame Etcheto looked at the two names while her lips went on moving.

Coralie didn’t look down. Her hands stayed on the handles of the wheelchair.

Lesca turned her head. Behind her the deputy mayor had his own copy of the speech out, with a finger under the second line of the third sheet. He turned the sheet over to see whether there was more on the back.

Nobody in the square made a sound. Out on the lake the gravel company’s machine was working. Then, at the plane trees, people turned to the people behind them, who had been too far away to hear or had been talking.

She watched her sentence travel back through the square and down the road, row by row, at walking pace. Here and there a hand went up to a mouth. Along the road phones rose above the heads, held out towards a stage their owners couldn't see. Beyond the last loudspeaker a man thought she had finished and began to clap. Three or four people clapped with him, then stopped.

A child asked what the lady had done. Somebody told the child.

The camera stayed on her, but the man behind it took his eye away and looked at her over the top of it. Kévin was by the loudspeaker with the cable in his fist. Sarthou held the flag and kept his eyes to the front.

The priest looked at his shoes. Her mother left the church wall and walked forward until she was close enough to read the letters on the stone.

At the foot of the steps Larrère had his book open in his hands. He shut it. When the people nearest him turned to look at him, he took his hat off. He was looking at Maïté. She was looking at the flowers.

The fourth sheet was the thanks: to the State, to the emergency services and to the village of Hontaube for lending its pumps. Lesca put the four sheets back together and left the fourth unread.

The young man from Pau looked at his watch. The mayor still had time left.

Nobody came up the steps. Nobody shouted. Lesca stood where she had been put. It was her ceremony. She had written the order of it herself, and the next item was printed on the programme.

'Madame Castagnet will lay the flowers,' she said into the microphone.

Maïté came up the steps with the flowers in both hands and her bag on her wrist. She didn't hurry. She crossed the stage in front of Lesca, bent down and set the flowers against the granite, under the names. Then she pulled the ribbon straight so that it could be read.

The prefect's photographer came to the front of the stage with his camera raised.

Lesca stayed on the tape. Maïté stood up, a metre from her, and turned her cheek away before anyone could ask for it.

The prefect didn't come back to the microphone. He went down the steps at the side of the stage, where his driver had the door of the grey car open before he reached it. At 11 he had shaken Lesca's hand. He left without shaking it again.

That left the young man from Pau at the bottom of the steps with his clipboard. He turned a sheet over and turned it back. Then he came up onto the stage, walked to the cross of white tape and stopped with his shoes just short of it.

‘I’ve got nothing on the sheet for this,’ he said. ‘I’ve been asked to ask. Whether the prefect might have the medal back, until things are clearer.’

She wore the medal one day a year, pinned to her good coat, because the prefect’s office liked it on camera. Its case was in her pocket. She unpinned the medal, laid it in the case and held the case out to him across the tape. He took it. She let him go without a word.

The crowd was leaving, down the road to the Port and the bar in the reception tent. People looked back as they went. The cameraman was folding up the stand.

Her mother hadn’t gone home. She was waiting below the stone with her bag on her arm.

‘Jean Castagnet shut the gates of my field behind him,’ Arlette said. ‘He was the only one on those fields who did. They’ll be in my kitchen tomorrow morning with this, the whole of the Port. I’ve listened to them about the lake for you, and about the four houses, over my own coffee. I’m not listening to this one. They can take it up your steps.’

‘Yes.’

‘And I’m not asking you why,’ her mother said. ‘I don’t want to be told.’

She went home around the back of the church, the way that didn’t pass the stone. After that there was nobody at the foot of the steps.

Marie-Jo came up onto the stage. Since the night of the plastic bag she had spoken to Lesca only in council meetings, and then only to the wall.

‘Maylis,’ she said.

Lesca waited for the rest.

‘There are two hundred chairs in this square. I counted them out of the hall at 7. Kévin’s down on the bank with the loudspeakers, in the coat you gave him when he came out of prison. Somebody has to stack the chairs.’

Lesca was still stacking chairs in the square when the care home came out of the hall after its lunch. Nadine pushed the wheelchairs past her to the minibus one at a time. As Madame Etcheto's went by, the old woman put her hand on the wheel and stopped it.

'Inguma never came last night,' she said. 'I said my words, and I waited for it in bed until morning. Where was it?'

'It was with me.' Lesca put down the chair she was carrying. 'I was in the hall where the dead play, and they called twelve.'

Madame Etcheto's hands closed on her handbag.

'That's my door.'

'Not this door. There are two of me, Madame Etcheto, and the other one has a room twelve under her bank. I took my river over there with me. And in the hall, when they called twelve, somebody sat down.'

'Then it wasn't Inguma that came for her,' Madame Etcheto said. 'It was you.'

'Yes.'

Madame Etcheto waited for more. There wasn't any.

'I heard that river go away, the night you turned your handle. It went like a bath emptying.' She took her hand off the wheel. 'Nobody emptied hers.'

Nadine turned the wheelchair towards the minibus. Madame Etcheto kept looking at Lesca until the chair had turned her away.

* * *

That evening Maïté let Lesca in without asking why she had come. Maïté still had her black coat on. On the kitchen wall beside the door hung an old phone with a cord, with a clock above it.

'I had a verb,' Maïté said. 'For the stone. I had it ready at that table, and your timer rang. *Left*. He was left out there. I wanted that word cut under his name, with yours under it.'

‘It would have been true of both names. I left him.’

‘Yes.’ Maïté went to the door and held it open. Then she looked up at the edge of the roof, in the light from the kitchen. ‘That back gutter’s blocked again. Have a look at it before you go.’

Lesca set the ladder against the edge of the roof and Maïté held it. The gutter was packed solid. Lesca cleared it by hand, dropping the rotten leaves past Maïté’s shoulder in black handfuls.

At the bottom of the garden somebody lifted the catch of the gate.

Larrère had come up the back lane on foot, without a torch, in the coat he had worn at the stone. He stopped at the garden gate with his hand on it and his face turned up to the ladder.

‘He used to come up that lane on duck nights, to the kitchen,’ Maïté said. She kept her eyes on the ladder. ‘Since the flood he comes as far as the gate, and I don’t open it.’

She turned her head and spoke down the garden.

‘You knew he was out there, Guy. You stood in my kitchen that night and rang her from my phone, with his van gone down to the fields, and you never told the woman you’d sent to the gate.’

Down in the Port a firework went up from the reception on the bank and lit him red, then white.

‘I’ll be brief,’ he said.

Maïté gave him time. He looked at the lit kitchen window, then at Maïté.

He said nothing.

He took his hand off the gate and went back down the lane in the dark.

Maïté put her hand back on the ladder. Lesca finished the gutter, hung the ladder on its hooks and went home by the front way.

* * *

The village council met on Tuesday at 6 with one item on the sheet. The deputy mayor took the chair for it, which left his own seat empty, halfway down the table.

Thirteen people were already sitting when Lesca came in with the sash on. For eleven years they had stood behind their chairs until she sat. She took the empty seat. Then she lifted the sash over her head, folded it in three and laid it in front of her, with the keys of the town hall on top.

Marie-Jo looked at the sash.

‘That the council ask the prefect to remove the mayor,’ the deputy mayor read, with a finger under the line. ‘The member concerned may speak on it.’

‘For three minutes,’ the secretary said. ‘On any item. That’s the mayor’s—’ She looked down at her register. ‘That’s the rule.’

Marie-Jo turned the white kitchen timer to three and stood it beside the sash.

Lesca had made the rule in her first month, for Larrère. For eleven years she had watched that timer tick from the head of the table. It was louder from here.

Larrère sat across from her with his association’s book shut and both hands on it. He had waited eleven years for this item. He didn’t ask to speak on it.

The table waited to hear her account. Every December in this room she had given it forty houses and a care home, in less than a minute. On Saturday she had given the square the rest, into a microphone.

She took the dial and turned it back to nothing. The bell rang.

‘That’s the member’s time,’ Marie-Jo said. ‘It goes to the vote.’

‘Those in favour,’ the deputy mayor said.

Marie-Jo’s hand went up first. The others followed around the table, one at a time, until there were eleven. Three of them lived in the Port, in houses that had stayed dry. Their hands were no slower than the rest.

Larrère kept both of his on the book.

‘Against,’ the deputy mayor said.

No hand went up. The deputy mayor looked down the table at the book.

‘I abstain,’ Larrère said.

The secretary counted the hands and wrote the number down. Then her pen came up again.

‘The motion is carried, Madame le—’ She stopped. The pen stayed where it was.

‘Lesca, Maylis,’ Lesca said. ‘Surname first.’

* * *

That night Lesca was sitting on the edge of her bed when Coralie came up the stairs and stopped on the landing.

‘It was in the care home before the council had its coats on,’ Coralie said. She had her hand on the spare-room door. ‘So that’s eleven years of Madame le maire gone, and I need something to call you. The gendarmes say Madame Lesca. I’m not saying that across a landing.’

She stayed there a moment longer, four steps away.

‘Good night, Maylis,’ she said, and went into the spare room.

Lesca left her door open and the lamp on.

At first light on Sunday 13 December Maylis walked down into the Port. Grey mud covered the road from wall to wall. Her boots sank in it to the ankle.

The water had gone back out through the gap as the river dropped. All along the road furniture stood on the pavements: mattresses on end, a cupboard with its drawers out. The doors of the care home were open and there was nobody inside. On Saturday the ambulances had taken the forty-one to Bayonne. The door of room twelve was shut, with a strip of the gendarmes' tape across it.

Larrère's car was at the crossroads with the driver's door open, stuck in mud up to the bottom of its doors. He was coming down the road on foot, carrying a cardboard folder at shoulder height. The folder was dry. His trousers were grey with mud to the knee.

Sarthou stood in the road outside the last house, in uniform, with his cap on. He let Larrère come to within a metre of him.

'They tell me,' Larrère said, and stopped.

Behind Sarthou the door of his house stood open. The water had left its mark along the wallpaper at the height of a table. Two doors up, Madame Darrigrand stood on the pavement beside a baby carriage, with the baby inside her coat. The carriage was full of mud up to the hood.

Larrère turned to Maylis, opened the folder on his forearm, took out her resignation and held it up.

Saturday 12 December 2026 was written in the gap, in his handwriting, above her tall L. She had been afraid of that date since 1 December. It was the smallest thing that had happened to her since Friday.

'Received and accepted yesterday,' he said. 'That gate went up without a word from me, with your key in another man's hand. The key goes in my tray.'

'And the other sheet?' Maylis said. 'The one with a name on it.'

Larrère looked at Sarthou and shut the folder.

'There is no other sheet,' he said.

'There is a file,' Sarthou said. He said it to her, with his eyes on his notebook. 'It has a name in it. The

keyholder was under an order to remain at the gate. At 2:57 she left it. That is recorded. I am not saying that I would have stayed there myself.'

'You had the key,' Madame Darrigrand said.

'Yes.'

'I'd rather you heard it from me than from the café.' She wiped the handle of the baby carriage with her sleeve. 'At 5 on Friday it was light, and Castagnet was up on the bank at your van window. He's said so in the Port. You had the key on your belt then. At 3 you were a kilometre away, fetching a man out of a dry hole. Sarthou carried my baby out over his head.' She turned to Larrère. 'And I signed a paper for that gate. It went in through your car window.'

Larrère turned around in the mud, holding the folder up out of it, and went back to his car.

Maylis measured it in her head, from the trapdoor to Madame Darrigrand's door. It was closer to a kilometre and two hundred metres. She didn't correct Madame Darrigrand.

* * *

The village van was still across the track in the dip, nose to nose with Jeannot's. The river had been over both of them. Then it had gone back out through the open gate with the tides and left the track grey. Kévin backed his own van down, hooked a chain onto the back of the village van and pulled it tight.

'How long has Castagnet been writing to the town hall about this dip?' he said. 'Is it out of gear? It'll come.'

It came on the third pull, backwards, with its door hanging open and mud on both seats. The seats could be cleaned. The engine was finished.

'What do I owe you?'

'Nothing. You looked the other way for four winters, for nothing, so I can do a morning.' He rolled up the chain. 'The boxes stood on the pavement at the care home until the battery died. I tipped them back in the river.'

'You told me on Friday not to keep that gate shut for you,' Maylis said. 'I didn't. That wasn't why.'

Kévin hung the chain on its hook and sat down on the step of his van.

He held up his left hand.

'On Saturday in that yard, in the water, with the chair in my hands, I counted. I got five, and I counted them again.' He closed the hand. 'I wanted six, Maylis. I've never wanted anything so much.'

‘It was five,’ she said.

He towed the village van up onto the bank for her. Then he went back down with the chain for Jeannot’s.

* * *

The Bayonne bus was standing at the church with its engine running. Maïté came along the road from the high ground in her good coat, carrying a light brown suitcase with two straps. She didn’t look at the café, and nobody came out of it.

She handed the suitcase up to the driver. She had the fare ready in her glove, in coins, but it wasn’t enough. The driver looked at the coins, then at the suitcase, and let her on.

The bus left. Josiane watched it go from the café door with a cloth in her hand.

‘I said it was in that house,’ she said. ‘I only had the one name wrong.’

Maylis went past her into the café for bread. It stood in its crate on the counter. The card game was on at its table, with old Bordenave beside it, holding the pad. Jeannot’s stool was empty.

The door opened behind her and somebody came in out of the cold.

‘Late,’ the dealer said to him, without looking up from the cards. ‘Had the key and went for a walk, did you?’

Then he looked up and saw her at the counter.

The cards stayed in his hand. Bordenave’s pencil stayed on the pad. Josiane took a loaf out of the crate, laid it on the counter and counted the change into Maylis’s left hand one coin at a time.

Maylis took the loaf out past the village hall. Marie-Jo was at its door with the keys, counting stacked chairs back against the wall. She looked at the loaf, then at the way Maylis held her side.

‘I had the coffee pot on in here at 3:30 on Saturday morning, and I counted them in,’ she said. ‘My son’s van came up that hill three times. He says you sent it.’ She pulled a chair off the stack and stood it on its legs. ‘One,’ she said, in the voice she called the numbers in. ‘Just the one. Sit down on it.’

Maylis sat down.

* * *

Coralie came in at 9 that evening. Maylis was in the kitchen with the kettle on. Coralie had been in her uniform since Friday afternoon, and it had dried on her twice.

‘Larrère’s put a date on my letter,’ Maylis said.

Coralie went to the oven, opened the door a few centimetres and bent down to the gap.

‘The date,’ she said, in the voice that came from the back of the throat. ‘There’s the question of the—’

She stayed bent over for a moment with her hand on the door. Then she shut it and sat down at the kitchen table in her coat. The shopping pad was on the table. It had a week of empty boxes on it, and under them the one she had drawn for Friday night.

‘Room twelve,’ she said. ‘I’ll say what it is to me, and then I won’t say it again. Every late shift since I started there I’ve stood at that door at lights-out while she said her words to the wardrobe, and her care plan said I wasn’t to join in. On Friday at 10 she wouldn’t sleep in a chair, and I walked her back to her room on my arm. You wrote to me to move her, and I wouldn’t wake her. That part is mine. Her daughter is having her buried here on Tuesday. I’m not telling you this so that you’ll carry less of yours. You had the key.’

‘I had the key.’

‘And on Friday you asked me back, on a doorstep, and I said 7.’ Coralie laid both hands flat on the table. ‘At 7 I was in a hall counting heads, and you were in it with me, and nobody was in the house.’ Her voice stayed steady. ‘And before 7 I’d asked you one thing, down a phone, with the water at my back door. The gate, or Castagnet. You said both. I know that word. I’ve cooked it.’

‘It wasn’t Either at the dip,’ Maylis said. ‘The van went in, and I had to pick one. I picked.’

‘I know what you picked. I was the other one.’

Coralie reached over to the fruit bowl and took a new envelope from behind it, from the place where her form used to stand. It had been cut open along the top. She laid it beside the pad.

‘Bayonne’s written. The geriatric floor, on nights. I start in January.’

‘Stay.’

‘That’s what you want,’ Coralie said. She turned the envelope around on the table. ‘I want that floor. I trained on it, under Ithurbide. A floor and a night of my own to run, where I say who gets turned and who’s left to sleep. I wanted it before Friday, and I want it more now. I can’t stand at that door at lights-out again.’

‘It’s twenty minutes. You could drive in from here.’

‘Don’t give me the measurement. I could. I’m not going to.’

She went upstairs. Maylis followed her as far as the bedroom door and found she had brought the pad with her.

Coralie packed one bag on the bed, out of the chest of drawers. Three uniforms went in, then the good coat, folded, then the clock she woke up to. Maylis stood in the doorway holding the pad in both hands and watched the bag fill. It wasn't much. She took more than that to the dump in a morning.

'I've asked you one question for sixteen years, and drawn you boxes for it,' Coralie said, without turning around. 'You've got a week of them in your hands. I'll ask it once more, with no box. What do you want, Maylis?'

'Madame Etcheto's being buried here on Tuesday. I want to dig the grave myself.'

Coralie shut the bag.

'Then you'll dig it. With that side. I'll strap it first.'

She carried the bag down and stood it by the front door. In the kitchen she got out the first-aid box she had brought home from work. Maylis sat while Coralie strapped the rib, with three turns of the wide bandage, pulled tight. She tucked the end in. Her hand stayed on it a little longer than a bandage needs.

Then she went upstairs. Maylis heard her cross the landing to the spare room and come out again. She heard her on every stair coming down, all eleven, slower than she had gone up. She heard the passage, then the front door, then the car door shutting on a pillow.

* * *

That night Maylis got into the middle of the bed, on her back, and waited for Inguma. There was one pillow on the bed.

At 2:51 Inguma came down and sat on her. She kept still under it. Then she was in the chair with Lesca. They got up out of it and faced each other, while Inguma waited just inside the door.

The wall where the hall had been was steel again. Lesca's right hand hung open at her side. She didn't call anything to order.

Maylis had the card from her raincoat in her hand. *left*. Lesca was holding the one from the shelf. *right*. It was the same handwriting, with the t crossed low.

'Forty-one,' Maylis said.

Lesca didn't answer.

'Is yours in the house?' Maylis said.

'Across the landing. Four steps. Yours?'

‘She took the pillow.’ Maylis looked at the door. ‘Don’t come again.’

‘I won’t.’

It came out whole.

One lamp went out. Then the other.

In the dark the dry sound started on the steel floor, but Inguma didn’t come to the chair. It went out over the step of the door. As it went, the steel under its leaves knocked against the steel of the frame, like one part of the room touching another. Then the door shut behind it on the rubber seal.

Neither of them sat down.

Maylis woke under her own lampshade. Her phone said 02:54. There was nothing on the wardrobe.

* * *

The cemetery was above the village and had stayed dry. On Monday morning, when Maylis came up, the priest was at the gate under his umbrella.

‘Tomorrow at 10,’ he said. ‘Madame Etcheto’s daughter wants the words her mother said each night to be said over her. I’ve had them written out for me, and I’m not sure they’re a prayer.’

‘They’re for a thing that sits on you.’

‘They’ll do.’ He looked at the place by the wall, next to Monsieur Etcheto’s grave. ‘You’ll dig it? Monsieur Larrère tells me the village has no outdoor worker this morning.’

‘Then it gets dug for nothing,’ Maylis said. ‘Yes.’

‘It’s the eighth this year. I keep count.’

He went down to his car. She took the pegs and the string from the tool hut, set the first peg at the head, measured the length and the width from it and ran the string around the four pegs.

She cut the grass along the string with the edge of the shovel, left-handed. It was a morning’s work for two arms. She had one.

Jeannot came up the path from the gate with an envelope in his hand and stopped at the foot of the string.

‘I’ve got a letter,’ he said, ‘and I’ve brought it by hand. I paid to register forty-one of them, to get Larrère’s name on a card, and I never got it once. I’m not paying for this one.’

He held it out. In the top left corner he had written *No. 42*.

‘It’s not a complaint,’ he said. ‘I started it as one. It’s the first one that isn’t. It’s for my cousin Sarthou, with a copy for the mayor’s tray. It says that at 3 on Saturday morning the keyholder was at the trapdoor of my hut, a kilometre from her gate, pulling me out of it by the neck. It says why she thought she had to. It says the cellar was dry. It says the handle stopped at nineteen, and who had been written to about it. It says the gate went up under my hands at 3:20, and that it took two arms and a knee. You had the one arm.’

‘The arm is the excuse you’ve written for me. It isn’t mine,’ Maylis said. ‘At 3 I never tried the handle.’

Jeannot turned the envelope over. ‘It says who had rung her, and from whose kitchen. My cousin got that off the screen of your phone on Saturday, and he’s my cousin.’

‘Maïté left on the bus.’

‘I saw the wardrobe.’ He turned the envelope back. ‘You told me twice to put it in forty-two. It’s in. It’s four pages, and it doesn’t thank you. I was in no danger, and I’ll say so to anyone. But they’re saying you went for a walk, and I was what you walked to. That goes in writing.’

She took the letter and buttoned it into her chest pocket.

He looked at the string, at the cut grass, at the way she held the shovel.

‘Whose is it?’

‘Madame Etcheto’s.’

‘She gave my mother her first communion dress.’ He looked around. A second shovel was leaning against the wall of the tool hut, where Maylis’s father had kept it. ‘You won’t get that down two metres with one arm, Lesca.’

He went and got it. Then he stepped over the string in his rubber boots and began to dig.